

March 2024

Call Order 011: ASEC Exploratory Interviews

Final Report

Prepared for:

U.S. Census Bureau
Center for Behavioral Science Methods
Suitland, MD

Prepared by:

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1. Project Background

In addition to providing data on employment and unemployment, the Current Population Survey is the vehicle for several important supplemental question modules, including the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC). The ASEC collects data on income sources, health insurance, and participation in various economic support programs. ASEC data also support the creation of the Supplemental Poverty Measure and are thus critically important to a broad array of data users.

To support development of new questions on health insurance and income/public assistance topics for the ASEC supplement, RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS), conducted 50 one-on-one exploratory qualitative interviews. Interviews were split (i.e., 25 each) across two topic ASEC topic areas—health insurance and income. The purpose of the exploratory interviews was to learn more about how respondents think about these topics, identify possible issues that may hinder a respondent’s ability to respond to questions about these topics, and gather feedback that can be used to draft easily understandable questions that can be answered accurately.

This report details the study methods, including the description of the target population and participant eligibility criteria, the strategies of participant recruitment and screening, and the interviewing procedures. Findings from exploratory interviews are also presented in detail, with recommendations offered where appropriate.

2. Methodology

This section provides an overview of the recruitment and interviewing methodologies used during ASEC health insurance and income exploratory interview data collection. Specifically, this section includes an overview of recruitment strategies and targets, presents participant characteristics for each topic area, and provides details about the protocols and procedures that were used during interviews.

2.1 Recruitment Methods

The RTI/RSS team recruited participants for the ASEC exploratory qualitative interviews from November 15, 2023, to January 16, 2024.

The recruitment for the exploratory interviews for health insurance and income topics began by identifying multiple metropolitan areas across all four Census regions that have relatively large and diverse populations for a potential larger proportion of residents who met the recruitment criteria of both subprojects. The RTI/RSS team then posted online recruitment advertisements in the selected metropolitan areas, releasing advertisements on a rolling basis to maintain a steady stream of prospective recruits for screening and scheduling.

The Census Bureau programmed a web-based eligibility screening in Qualtrics. The RTI/RSS team also established a toll-free telephone line dedicated to recruitment purposes. The web link of the screening instrument and the toll-free phone number were presented in the online advertisements (see **Appendix A**) to support participant recruitment.

During the data collection period, the RTI/RSS team provided the Census Bureau with a weekly recruitment and interviewing progress update report, reflecting results to date. The weekly report sought to present the diversity of interview participants with respect to recruitment goals and needed sub-characteristics. The results of ASEC exploratory interview recruitment presented in **Section 2.1.3** of this report reflect the final recruitment outcomes.

2.1.1 Implementation of Recruitment Advertising

The RTI/RSS team used Craigslist as the main venue for recruitment advertising. Craigslist is one of the best-known online bulletin boards and provides the most comprehensive coverage of metropolitan areas in the United States. Based on past experience with previous call orders, RTI/RSS has been able to successfully recruit participants for qualitative research with diverse demographic and socioeconomic characteristics from Craigslist, with the exception of identifying some hard-to-reach sub populations such as those with racial or ethnic backgrounds that account for small percentages of the general population. To leverage Craigslist's broad reach while recruiting general population samples, RTI/RSS did not use targeted advertisements that focused on specific characteristics and

used a general advertisement instead (see **Appendix A** for recruitment materials and advertisement text).

The RTI/RSS team began the participant recruitment by posting the general recruitment advertisement on Craigslist under the “jobs/et cetera” sections for the six metropolitan areas across all four Census regions. RTI/RSS staff also reached out to their personal networks to solicit participation from those who may fit our recruitment criteria and asked their personal contacts to refer others who might be eligible for the participant recruitment screener (i.e., word of mouth). The first round of monthly paid advertising started on November 15, 2023, and expired on January 7, 2024. The team posted the first two general advertisements for the metropolitan areas of Columbus, Ohio, and Dallas/Fort Worth, Texas. The recruitment screener had received a few dozen completions within 24 hours and continued to receive completions at a consistent rate for approximately 1 week afterward.

As the receipt of completions gradually decreased, the team posted the third general advertisement for Orlando, Florida, on November 26 to maintain the momentum of recruitment screening. The fourth and fifth general advertisements for Salt Lake City, Utah, and Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, were posted on December 5, followed by the sixth posting for San Diego, California, on December 10. RTI/RSS team recorded screening responses for more than 600 prospective participants from this first round of advertising.

2.1.2 Participant Selection Strategy

To facilitate efficient screening review and participant selection between health insurance and income exploratory interviews, the RTI/RSS team created three automated spreadsheets. First, the team created a main intake sheet to import the screening responses from Qualtrics. The main intake sheet was used to determine the main eligibility criteria (i.e., adults age 18 or older, lives in the U.S., and meets one or more recruitment criteria outlined in **Tables 2.1, 2.2, 2.3, and 2.4** presented in **Section 2.1.3**) for ASEC exploratory qualitative interviews health insurance and income topics.

Within the main intake spreadsheet, the RTI/RSS team employed a two-step review strategy to determine topical interview assignment and participant selection priority. The spreadsheet first calculated and presented the number of eligible respondent characteristics for both health insurance and income interviews. The lead recruiter then selected and assigned prospective recruits to the topic area (i.e., health insurance or income) for which they had the most eligible characteristics or represented a criterion relatively more difficult to fulfill (see **Tables 2.1, 2.2, 2.3, and 2.4** presented in **Section 2.1.3**). Next, the lead recruiter reviewed the tentative assignment of all prospective participants on the intake sheet, focusing on contact information self-reports and the IP addresses in the paradata for de-duplicated entries from the same individuals and excluding ineligible entries from foreign IP addresses.

After reviewing and cleaning the tentative assignments, the records of eligible recruits were exported to either health insurance or income specific recruitment tracking sheets. The allocation of eligible recruits is determined by (1) the fulfillment status of the required quota of the primary criteria and (2) the balance of the household and demographic characteristics in the secondary criteria. The interview assignment–specific spreadsheets served as the main reference for recruitment and interview progress for the entire project team, including for the recruiters and interviewers. For ASEC exploratory qualitative interviews, the team used the ASEC Health Insurance recruitment tracker and ASEC Income recruitment tracker to account for different needs of topics and support the recruitment effort for the interviews.

During data collection, RTI/RSS team processed and reviewed the screening data at least once a week to select eligible participants for an interview. After a batch of screening data were reviewed, about 1 week would elapse before new assignments would be made to allow recruiters sufficient time to contact their existing assignments. How quickly interviewers contacted a selected participant after their assignment varied based on several factors, including the interviewer’s case load at the time of assignment, the number of scheduled interviews, and the speed with which other participants responded to the interviewer’s contact attempts.

2.1.3 ASEC exploratory qualitative interview recruitment outcomes

During the data collection, RTI/RSS received 836 screening responses, including 13 respondents who were screened by phone. A total of 667 recruits were considered eligible to participate in the study based on their screening responses. Sixty-four recruits were excluded during the selection review process. These potential recruits were excluded after examining responses to screener questions and fell into one of more of the following exclusion categories: (1) they were unwilling to share their screen, (2) provided inconsistent responses over multiple screening attempts, or (3) completed the screening from a questionable IP address (i.e., a foreign IP address).

The RSS team completed 25 exploratory qualitative interviews for the health insurance topic while the RTI team completed 25 interviews about income. Across both health insurance and income interview efforts, RTI/RSS also selected and contacted 40 eligible participants who did not complete the interview; 26 participants did not respond to our invitation, 11 of them did not show up for their scheduled interview, and another three decided to withdraw their participation after they were scheduled for an interview.

Health Insurance Participants

Table 2.1 details the distribution of the completed interviews with the primary recruitment criteria for the topic of health insurance for the ASEC exploratory qualitative interviews. It includes the required recruitment targets of participants who are not the policyholder for their insurance, those who do not have access to regular care, those who have had a life

event in the past year (marriage, divorce, children, new job), those who have experienced a spell of unemployment, those who have performed nonstandard or seasonal work, and those who enrolled in Medicaid or other plans for people with low incomes. At the time of screening, eight participants reported having Medicaid. However, 10 participants had Medicaid at the time of the interview. One participant had misreported during screening, and another participant started receiving Medicaid between screening and completing the interview. **Table 2.2** presents the soft targets of other demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography of the health insurance exploratory interview participants.

Table 2.1. Primary Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews

Primary Criteria		
	Completed	Goal
Under 65	25	25
Policy holder: No	8	At least 4
Access to care: No	10	At least 4
Life event: At least one	12	At least 4
Spell of unemployment	13	At least 4
Nonstandard work	18	At least 5
Medicaid	8	At least 4

Table 2.2. Secondary Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews

Household Composition		
	Completed	Goal
Lives with at least one other person	21	At least 20
Lives with unrelated individuals	10	At least 8
Lives with immediate/ extended family	13	At least 12
Lives with children	8	At least 6
Participant Characteristics		
	Completed	Goal
<i>Sex</i>		
Male	14	At least 10
<i>Race/Ethnicity</i>		
Non-white non-Hispanic	9	At least 4
Hispanic	5	At least 4

Household Composition		
	Completed	Goal
<i>Geography</i>		
Northeast	6	At least 4
Midwest	6	At least 4
West	5	At least 4
South	8	At least 4
<i>Education</i>		
Less than college	14	At least 8
Some college/college	7	At least 4
Post-graduate	4	At least 4
<i>Age</i>		
18–35	6	At least 4
36–50	13	At least 4
51–64	6	At least 4
<i>Unlikely to respond online/screened in by phone</i>	5	At least 5

Income Participants

Table 2.3 details the distribution of the completed ASEC exploratory qualitative interviews with the primary recruitment criteria for the topic of income. It includes the required recruitment targets of participants who received income from retirement or pensions, those who received income from unemployment benefits or workers compensation, those who are self-employed, those who received income from interests and dividends, and those who participate in program such as Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), Women, Infants, and Children program (WIC), Free and Reduced-Price School Lunch, or other public assistance programs. **Table 2.4** further presents the soft targets of other demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography of the participants of the income exploratory interviews.

Table 2.3. Primary Characteristics for Income Interviews

Primary Criteria		
	Completed	Goal
Retirement/pensions	8	At least 5
Unemployment/workers comp	7	At least 5
Interest and dividends	14	At least 5
Self-employment	6	At least 5
Program participation	10	At least 5

Table 2.4. Secondary Characteristics for Income Interviews

Household Composition		
	Completed	Goal
Lives with at least one other person	16	At least 20
Lives with unrelated individuals	3	At least 8
Lives with immediate/extended family	14	At least 12
Lives with children	5	At least 6
Participant Characteristics		
	Completed	Goal
<i>Sex</i>		
Male	10	At least 10
<i>Race/Ethnicity</i>		
Non-white non-Hispanic	8	At least 4
Hispanic	4	At least 4
<i>Geography</i>		
Northeast	3	At least 4
Midwest	5	At least 4
West	3	At least 4
South	14	At least 4
<i>Education</i>		
High school or less	4	At least 8
Some college/college	18	At least 4
Post-graduate	3	At least 4
<i>Age</i>		
18–35	6	At least 4
36–50	7	At least 4
51–64	4	At least 4
65+	8	At least 10
<i>Unlikely to respond online/screened in by phone</i>	10	At least 5

2.2 Interview Protocols and Procedures

Census Bureau developed two separate and distinct protocols that focused on each of the two topic areas being explored in this study: one for health insurance (**Appendix B**) and

one for income (**Appendix C**). RTI/RSS provided input and reviewed each protocol. Both protocols included a mix of open-ended “exploratory” questions designed to assess participants’ general knowledge and understanding of different domains under each topic area (i.e., health insurance; income) and questions designed to evaluate participants’ understanding for a subset of specific draft ASEC questions. Both protocols were designed to be completed in 1 hour or less. On average, health insurance topic interviews took 46 minutes to complete and ranged from 27 minutes to 65 minutes. Income topic interviews took an average of 49 minutes to complete and ranged from 18 minutes to 78 minutes. For the income interview that lasted over 1 hour, the observer had additional questions at the end of the interview.

Once finalized, interview protocols were programmed in Qualtrics to facilitate virtual interviewing. Respondent-facing instruments that contained the draft ASEC health insurance and income questions being tested were also programmed on the web. During the interview, participants were either provided a link to ASEC topic-specific questions (i.e., health insurance or income) and asked to respond to questions while sharing their screen, or the interviewer displayed the web instrument containing ASEC questions on screen and asked participants to respond while entering responses for them.

All interviews were conducted remotely using Microsoft Teams within Census Bureau’s secure Virtual Desktop Interface (VDI) environment or using a Census Bureau issued laptop. With permission from participants, interviewers recorded all sessions using handheld audio recording devices or, when available, SnagIt software. Recordings were saved to the designated deliverable folder in the Census Bureau file share location. After each interview, interviewers completed the appropriate case summary template for the topic area (i.e., health insurance or income). At the end of the interview, interviewers offered participants a \$40 Visa digital gift code as a thank you for their time.

Although the two protocols and respondent-facing instruments differed, each interview was conducted in the following sequence to standardize implementation:

- Explain the purpose of the study.
- Confirm participant had reviewed and signed the online consent form to participate in the study and be audio/video recorded (**Appendix D**).
- Start audio recording using an external audio recorder or SnagIt software.
- Re-confirm verbal consent to participate and be recorded once recording has started.
- Ask open-ended “exploratory” questions.
- Share the respondent-facing instrument ask participants to answer ASEC questions shown on screen.
- Administer probes to ASEC questions.
- End the interview and send the participant the incentive.

- Save the recording within the Census Bureau’s secure network environment in the designated file share folder.
- Complete the interview summary and save it in the designated file share folder no more than 5 business days after each interview.

Before conducting exploratory interviews, all RTI/RSS interviewers were trained on protocols for each topic area (i.e., health insurance; income) and other key procedures, including Title 13 requirements. Because each topic area used different protocols, two interviewer training sessions were held: one that focused on the health insurance protocol and one that focused on the income protocol.

3. Findings

3.1 Health Insurance

This section presents results and recommendations, where appropriate, for ASEC Health Insurance questions by topic area. The interview consisted of an exploratory section where participants were asked in a semi-structured interview format about their health coverage and general knowledge about health insurance, the coverage of others in their household, and terminology used to refer to different aspects of health coverage. They were asked to provide some information from their insurance cards and probed on their preference for how to provide Census Bureau with information about their health insurance plan. All participants were then asked to complete ASEC health insurance questions (Set A) and were probed to better understand their responses and understanding of the questions. Findings in this section are presented by topic, with findings from exploratory questions first followed by cognitive testing questions.

3.1.1 Exploring Coverage and General Knowledge about Health Insurance

At the beginning of each interview, participants were asked a series of questions to establish where they go for medical care and how they pay for such care, followed by an exploration of their understanding of what health coverage involves and the varied terms that refer to it.

3.1.2 Medical Care and Coverage

Access to Care

Usual place for care. Participants were asked where they usually go when they want to see a doctor or other medical professional. Nine of the 25 participants reported going to see a doctor. Several of these participants used a variation of the term primary care physician or PCP, including: “PCP” (P212 and P445), “primary care physician” (417), or “primary physician” (P332, P620). Others used the terms “physician” (P56), “general practitioner” (P340), or “doctor’s office” (P500 and 549). Six participants said they usually go to a hospital or emergency room, six reported usually going to an urgent care center, and four reported usually going to a local clinic.

Overall, there was little relationship between participants’ health coverage and their answer to this question, but some participants did connect the two. For example, one participant explained that they had recently been going to the emergency room for care because they were uninsured but that the hospital recently helped them sign up for “emergency Medi-Cal” so they now have Medicaid coverage.

“More recently I’ve been having to go to the ER to seek medical care, I haven’t gone to an actual doctor’s office in a bit just because of my insurance.” (P405)

Another participant also said that their lack of insurance coverage led them to seek medical care in emergency rooms.

"Lately to the Emergency Room just because I didn't have insurance...I didn't have health insurance, but I have some now." (P313)

Notably, four of the six participants who reported usually going to an urgent care center for care also mentioned that they have a PCP but choose to go to an urgent care center because of the convenience and not needing to wait for an appointment.

"Urgent care or my primary physician. Lately, to urgent care. It's faster and I think it costs about the same." (P332)

"I just changed insurance, so I haven't been to my primary care providers and switched insurance. So, if I urgently needed care, I would probably just go to Urgent Care. But I usually don't go to the doctors. I'm usually pretty healthy." (P658)

"I guess it depends. For annual appointments I usually go to my PCP, but for things that pop up I usually go to urgent care." (P445)

Seeking specific types of medical care. In addition to where they usually go for medical care, participants were asked where they go for certain types of medical care. First, they were asked where they would go if they needed a vaccine or a check-up. If they needed to receive a vaccine, eight participants said that they would go to their PCP, three said that they would go to a hospital, two said that they would go to a local clinic, two said that they would go to their local Health Department, three said they would visit a pharmacy, and one participant said that they did not know where to go if they needed a vaccine. Participants were also asked where they would go if they needed a check-up. Of the 25 participants, 16 said they would go to their PCP, four said that they would go to a local clinic, two said that they would go to a hospital, one said that they would see a doctor online, one said that they would go to a clinic or urgent care, and one participant said that they do not go anywhere for check-ups.

"[For] Vaccines I go to one of our local pharmacies that I've done business with for a long time. For a checkup I still go to the same place, the local health clinic." (P76)

"For the vaccines, we went to the health department. They had an offer...whoever gets a vaccine gets a \$100 gift card." (P108)

"Vaccines, I go to CVS. Checkups, like I said physical usually once a year at my primary care." (P417)

"A vaccine, I'd probably go to Rite Aid. There's one nearby that does it. Or CVS. But a checkup, I'd probably try to get in contact with my primary care provider." (P658)

"Family physician." [I: For both a vaccine and a check-up?] "Yeah. They have it all in one building." (P359)

Participants were then asked where they would go if they were sick or injured. Again, we saw little relationship between participants' health coverage and their answers about where they would seek healthcare if sick or injured. Participants generally seemed to choose where to seek care based on how urgently they felt they needed attention: medicating or treating themselves for the least urgent needs, seeing a PCP if there is more of a need to be seen, going to urgent care when they need to be seen faster, and finally visiting the emergency room for the most urgent health needs.

Seventeen participants provided their answer based on hypothetical situations, as can be seen in the following quotes.

"If it's an emergency to the ER. If I can hold off, then I go to the doctor." (P56)

"Worst case scenario to the emergency room." [I: And if it's not a worst-case scenario?] P: "I'll self-medicate, I'll go to Walgreens and get what I need to try to make myself feel a little better, just to make sure, if not I'm going to the emergency room." (P108)

"I usually don't go when I'm sick, I find home remedies usually." [I: And if you're injured?] P: "I go to the hospital." (P283)

Five participants gave examples of past illnesses and injuries to illustrate what they do when they are sick or injured.

"That would be the urgent care. I have broken my middle toe. And I went there and then they x-rayed it and then they gave me a boot and then they told me to find a foot doctor. But that was the end of that, you know, I just wore the boot and then I never did go see the foot doctor because I would have to pay out of pocket for that and what not, but I probably still will need to go see the foot doctor.) (P132)

"Like over [D: HOLIDAY] I had a cold. I had laryngitis. I wanted my voice back. So, I went to Urgent care." (P718)

"Well, I guess it would depend upon the injury. I haven't, I can't think of any injuries I've had that I needed to see somebody, I did have a [D: Medical] a few years ago and so I was in pain, I didn't know at the time it was a [D:

Medical], so I went to the emergency room, at the closest hospital to me. And then if I'm sick, I usually take some medicine over the counter, something like that." (P417)

"If it was an open wound, yeah, I'd go to urgent care. If it was beyond all that, I'd go to the emergency room. If I was really sick, you know, and the doctor wasn't available, and like I couldn't function, somebody would drop me off probably. That's what happened last time. Yeah, and if I was hurt like I [D: Medical] once I'd go to the hospital because going to urgent care is just dumb. They don't have access to the machines, and I'd end up at the hospital anyways." (P500)

Paying for Care

Participants were asked about how they pay for healthcare when they are sick, and some were asked if there was a charge the last time they saw a doctor. Of the 25 participants, 23 said that their health insurance pays or has paid for their medical care. Of these 23, 11 said that they did not need to pay anything out of pocket the last time they saw a doctor or other medical professional. Of these who did not pay anything out of pocket, nine reported being on Medicaid while the other two had coverage through their job or a partner's job.

"Insurance pays. I just give them a policy number and they deal with everything else. I don't know how they pay it exactly." (P56)

"Actually, the last doctor visit I had was recently. I went to see a specialist, ENT doctor for my [D: Medical] and that was a referral from my primary care, and so there was no copay." (P417)

"It's through my employment. A certain amount is taken from my paycheck and that's how I pay for health insurance." [I: Do you have any other payments that you have to make when you go?] "That pretty much covers it." (P181)

"I'm on Medicaid, state Medicaid. There was no charge last time." (P76)

Of the 23 participants who had health coverage, 13 said that they have had to or will have to pay something out of pocket when they visit a doctor or other medical professional. These participants mostly mentioned co-pays, but some also explained that there are premiums, deductibles, or payments that come out of Health Savings Accounts (HSA) accounts.

"My wife's health insurance. She gets through her work. And we pay the co-pay, and that's it. But of course, she's paying, but out of her salary." (P332)

"I have insurance. Yes, there was a charge, it's like a co-pay. I paid like \$20." (P620)

“My spouse, my wife, has insurance through her company, and we have a deductible, and we also have an HSA so depending on the time of year, it either comes out of my pocket or the HSA, or if we have met the deductible, I don’t pay anything, the insurance covers it.” (P212)

“Yes. We have a high deductible plan so let’s say I break a leg and I have to go to the ER, there’s a copay for that type of visit, but if I need much medical attention... I think our deductible is \$3500 per person and \$5000 per family. So, I would be responsible for the first \$3500 and after that, insurance would pick up everything.” (P205)

Among the 13 participants who reported having to pay something out of pocket, two were participants who had also reported having Medicaid coverage. One of these participants had recently gotten emergency Medicaid and reported having to pay for part of a medical bill. The other participant was covered under Texas Health Woman, which only covers women’s health and family planning. This participant reported that they had been attending a non-profit clinic where they were able to just pay a \$20 co-pay, but they were recently dropped from the program and have been relying on an online doctor for things like high cholesterol, which is not covered by Texas Health Woman, so they were paying out of pocket for that doctor online.

Health Coverage

Understanding of “health coverage.” Participants were asked what the term “health coverage” meant to them. Some participants’ answers focused on which costs of healthcare are being covered while others focused on the types of care that is “covered” in their definitions. In particular, eight focused on costs of healthcare, 13 spoke about types of care or what health coverage “covered,” and four offered general answers. General answers included “safety, in case something happens” (P47), “health insurance” (P76 and P718), and “best health coverage you can get” (P108).

Some examples of those who focused on the cost include the following.

“Health coverage to me means that when I’m having health problems or health issues, that the majority of my expenses will be covered, be covered by the government, or covered by an employer when I’ve had employment, so that I’m paying either very little out of pocket or in this case since I’m not working and have Medi-Cal, not paying really anything.” (P417)

“It means the financial coverage that goes into healthcare. To pay for healthcare.” (P340)

“It’s the financial coverage, the coverage of the financial responsibilities whether I myself cover it or the insurance company covers it, and then of

course what items would be or would not be approved by the insurance company, if I need to get a scan or a procedure..." (P212)

"I would say like helping with your bills, taking care of the payments, for your health needs." (P620)

"They take care when you are in sickness or if you are injured, something that can help you out, so you won't have to spend expensive money at the hospital to where you have to come out your pocket." (P107)

Examples of those who focused on the healthcare itself include the following.

"I believe it would mean to me you know health coverage covers anything that is making you feel unwell and sick." (P132)

"To me it means covering your health, things that might happen that aren't expected, not meant to be used all the time but when you need it's there." (P283)

"Health, going to the hospital, getting vaccines, at least covering part of the medical, medicine prescriptions." (P359)

"It means that covers some of your health problems, depending on the plan you have, it covers for your medicines or dental. So, it depends." (P11)

"Health coverage is something where you are covering your health, I mean, health coverage, it's something where you are making sure... your well-being, it's a necessity." (P181)

Understanding of "health plan." Participants were also asked what "health plan" meant to them. Of the 25 participants, 15 described a "health plan" as the specific coverage one may have from their insurance company, which has more or less coverage depending on cost.

"A health plan to me means... a plan that fits maybe like your health, each person is different, some people might need better insurance depending on the medical health they need or if they're older, or if they're children, just different health plans." (P405)

"It means whatever group I've been assigned to, what they decide that they are going to offer as far as me being healthy and who I'm allowed to see in order to be healthy." (P500)

"To me is like the different plans. Like gold plan or bronze plan, the different plans that you can upgrade to or get...Some cover more on your medicines or doctor's fees."

"The plan is the overarching piece that says what is covered or not, this is how much you have to pay out of pocket, this is how much the premium is, kind of like the blueprint for the overall insurance plan we have for our family." (P212)

"Basically, the same, but I think when you say plan, I think a little bit more, I more picture the page or the PDF online that documents co-pays and what's covered, what's not covered, and yeah, costs and stuff like that." (P332)

Three participants did not seem familiar with the term "health plan" and imagined it might be a type of health-related savings plan or something like a treatment plan one puts together with a doctor.

"Health plan, I mean, definitely I don't know, when you're planning to get sick, then that would be like, I don't know, a bucket of funds that are available to cover you in the future when you get sick. That's what a plan is, is preparing." [I: And when you say a bucket of money, you mean your own money?] "Um, I guess. You have to pay for health care, so yeah." (P132)

"Well, insurance would be one way to pay for it, but I'm thinking there's probably other plans that aren't in like, I know there's like health savings accounts, not quite... I'm saying not always insurance because as far as I understand it, there's people who have health savings accounts. I'm not really sure how they work, but I think that would be a way to pay for health care outside of health insurance. I guess you would just use whatever's in that account to pay for whatever service, maybe [in] place of or in addition to insurance." (P658)

"I think for me that implies a treatment plan or care plan that me and my doctor come up with." (P445)

Understanding of "health insurance." In their definitions of "health insurance" four participants focused on the safety net aspect of health insurance and how it is something you need in case of a serious health need.

"Health insurance is a safety net. It helps. It pays for things you can't afford." (P56)

"Health insurance is insuring your health. Because without it, you are going to have a lot of bills coming in the mail. So, if you are a person that's prone to having certain illnesses, or you get sick, you need health insurance." (P181)

"Health insurance to me is safety. Safe to have it, just in case, it's not totally necessary but I would like my kids to have it, just in case." (P47)

Three focused more on health insurance being a way to pay for healthcare that can lower out-of-pocket costs.

"It is a plan to finance health care, typically covered by your employer. I say typically because sometimes, you know, with government-sponsored health plans, that wouldn't be your employer necessarily, it's usually an employer plan that arranges different ways for different services to be paid for, usually at a lower cost to, a lower out-of-pocket cost to the patient." (P658)

"Health insurance means you have some sort of support network that's supposed to help pay for medical costs, health plan is the plan that you select, determining how much you pay into it and how much they'll pay out if you get insured or sick." (P340)

One participant seemed to understand health insurance more as a guarantee to health providers that they will be paid for their services.

"Health insurance is, they are saying, they're telling the doctor that they're guaranteeing that the services will be covered. So, they don't have to come out of my pocket. I don't have to reimburse. But, yeah, so health insurance is, tell them that they're going to get paid either way. And then, of course, he's signing the paper saying, if my insurance drops me, I'll pay you anyways. But that's what I believe is designed to do, is to guarantee, ensure that the services are paid for." (P500)

"Health coverage" vs. "health plan" vs. "health insurance." When asked if the terms "health coverage," "health plan," and "health insurance" meant the same thing or had different meanings, 11 participants said that the terms meant the same thing to them or were interchangeable.

"I feel like they all essentially mean the same thing, like you're covered, you're insured, or the plan to help cover insure you." (P405)

"I know they mean different but to me they mean the same." (P175)

Fourteen participants said they saw these terms as having different meanings. Several understood "health plan" was different than "health coverage" and "health insurance" in that a plan included selecting among multiple options.

"I think health plan, health insurance is different. Health plan, I'm trying to think of a difference but there's plans you can get that aren't insurance and then there's health insurance." (P283)

"A health plan is something I would select out of choices and health insurance means I'm insured and that there's going to be some sort of help...Health

coverage sounds a little bit more positive; it sounds like you're covered, it sounds more like better than insurance I guess in that there's some sort of coverage if you get hurt or sick." (P340)

"Health plan means slightly different, like I said, I more think of specific plans, not the whole plans, but the specific plan, as opposed to like coverage, it's black and white, you either have it or you don't, is the way I think of it. And health insurance, I just think of the whole industry..." (P332)

"They're quite similar but they are different in their own ways. A health plan is all the different options that you have that your health insurance provider offers. The health insurance is ability for them to cover you and the health coverage is the details of what is and what isn't covered." (P313)

"I think health coverage and health insurance means the same thing but the health plan I think can be other things...When I think of a health plan, I think more of like a treatment plan between me and my doctor." (P445)

Participants were also asked which of these terms they hear used most often, and 17 said that they hear or use "health insurance" most often. Four participants said that they hear "health coverage" used most often. Three said they hear "health plan" most often. One participant said that they hear both "health plan" and "health insurance" used most often.

"Um, I hear health insurance. Because everywhere you go, do you have insurance? Give me your insurance card. I don't hear, do you have a plan? I never hear that. What's your health plan? And that's just like a futuristic thing, thinking. But insurance is always spread out everywhere. Because everywhere I go, I have to say, I don't have insurance." (P132)

3.1.3 Detailed Coverage and Knowledge Assessment

Next in the interview, participants were asked about their current coverage, how they signed up for it, any gaps in coverage they experienced, and the coverage of others in their household.

Current Coverage in Detail

In this section, participants with current coverage were asked about the length of that coverage and any gaps they may have had within that period. Sixteen participants whose coverage was less than 2 years old were asked about the previous coverage and again about length and gaps.

Of the 25 participants, 23 had coverage at the time of the interview. Fourteen of these 23 participants were able to provide a month and year when their coverage started, with some remembering specifically and others estimating. Of the 23, six remembered the year but not

the month. One participant (P181) remembered coverage started 2 years earlier in January, but they miscalculated and misreported the year in giving the date.

Signing Up

Participants were asked how they got their current coverage and what, if anything, they had to do to sign up for it. Their degree of knowledge about the signing up process varied, depending on how personally involved in signing up each of them was and whether they were the primary policyholder or they were covered through a family member's employer. In particular, two participants under age 26 who were covered through their parents had had the same coverage for many years and knew nothing about the signing up process, as this had happened when they were young children, about 20 and 18 years ago, respectively.

"[I've been covered] since my mom's worked for this company. So at least 18 years. I think my family took the current job in 2004." (P718)

"[I've had this coverage] for 20 years." (P620)

Three participants covered through a spouse's employer were more knowledgeable about the enrollment process. Still, some were more involved in that process than others.

"We were able to meet with my husband's HR representative to discuss the two different plans we could choose... She made sure all our questions were answered to select a plan. We were fortunate enough to be able to meet with someone. To sign up we had to fill out some forms which we sent to our HR representative, and she was responsible for signing us up." (P205)

"She [participant's spouse] got an email from her HR department with a link to go look at coverages, she clicked some boxes, looked at a few documents, and we said 'Oh, do we want vision?' Costs this much. We made some calculations. It took us maybe 10 minutes." (P212)

"We went on his [participant's spouse] employer's account and they had an option to sign up and you picked from a plan, and we had to fill up a bunch of paperwork and fax in some documents." (P576)

One participant was less engaged in the process their spouse followed with their employer and was a more passive recipient of the health coverage benefit.

"Um, I didn't have to do anything, and I can only guess, I don't know for sure, I'm guessing that when she (my wife) was hired it was just part of, you know a number of a handful of different things that you have to do when you're newly employed at a company." (P332)

Another participant reported getting coverage through their spouse's job, and not having to do anything to sign up themselves. The spouse got coverage and signed up the participant along with their two children. (P47)

Six participants who actively sought the insurance coverage from the Marketplace or from a government agency, the process was more active and typically involved signing up online.

"Online. You then talked to an agent or a government or somebody, then they send it to you. Everything is like through the government. It's called the Marketplace." (P11)

"...It's Texas Medicaid... I applied... I did it online. It took about like a month for it to go through and it went through, and everything went fine from there." (P56)

"I believe I just called, I called Medi-Cal directly. And I don't remember if there was either paperwork I filled out or I did it with somebody on the phone, I'm not sure. But nonetheless I had help from the government, whoever helps you with that kind of stuff and there's a waiting period obviously while they look at all the stuff, a few weeks or whatever and then I got a packet in the mail with all the details and what's covered and who to call and so forth and then a card came in the mail..." (P417)

Two participants who had similar sign-up processes (by telephone or web) appeared more detached from the process.

"Oh, I had to call the Texas SNAP or not, is it SNAP? The benefits, I don't know. Whatever's associated with that. And tell them that I wanted to get to the Texas Women's and then they said Okay. They did I through a computer, I guess. Then they started mailing me of all these things, so basically, yeah, just the same way you would sign up for Medicaid, I guess, that those people, I can't think of the name, I just called that number." (P132)

"The work I do. My employer." [I: Did you have to do anything yourself to sign up for it?] "No." [I: Did they automatically enroll you, can you tell me a little bit more about that process.] R: "They automatically enroll once I started working for the company." (P175)

Gaps in Coverage

Participants who had coverage were asked if there had been any months since they first got this coverage that they were not covered. Two participants did not appear particularly aware of their health insurance situation.

"Not that I'm aware of. Like I said I haven't used it, I haven't contacted them, they haven't reached out to me for anything..." (P313)

"Possibly, but I don't remember." (P359)

Among the six participants who did experience gaps in coverage, some explained that these gaps in coverage were money related, including high insurance costs or being offered an incentive by the insurance company.

"I stopped like for a month. And then I got it renewed again like two weeks ago." [I: Tell me more about that break in coverage.] "They wanted me to pay so much money on it. They tried to bill me for \$600-700." (P11)

"Absolutely, that was a bad time too 'cause I needed it. But I tried to switch out, you know how they say they give you 6500 bucks to switch over, to get groceries and stuff like that, I really believed that and they screwed me so I ain't have health care for four months." [I: Do you remember when that was?] R: "[D]. No, maybe April. April, June, July." [I: Of this year?] R: "Yeah." [I: So during that time you didn't any have coverage, right?] R: "No." (P108)

Another participant who was covered for 15 years experienced a gap in health coverage while homeless during which time they would go to the hospital.

"Oh, since I first got it? Yeah. So, I no longer qualified over or needed because of the job I had insurance. I had years before this too. I go up and down with meeting up with it. But yeah, I've been solid on it for the last 15." (P500)

"Anytime that I haven't been covered when I've needed it, it's been a hospital visit and the hospital really expedites it. They want it through and they want you to be approved for access. So, I mean if you need to get on access timely manner you go to the hospital and push it through as fast as they can... [I: So, for how long do you think you went without coverage in these 15 years?] "Oh, I think for a year sometimes, a couple months maybe, mostly big spaces like a year. [I: What have you done during that time that you did not have coverage?] "I ended up at the hospital, went to healthcare for the homeless which is very, very, very, very hard to find around here." (P500)

Two participants answered with regards to not having coverage broadly, explaining that they experienced a coverage gap during transitions to a new coverage.

"Yes, there was actually a month lapse when we were not covered by anything. It was a little stressful. We just did not plan accordingly so the last plan ended and there was a gap until the next one started. So, we tried not to

go to the clinic or have appointments during that month. That was in July 2023.” (P576)

“There was like a two to three week period. So, I did have a like a checkup appointment in I want to say September that I was going to go to, but when I scheduled it, I was on my older insurance, which was the school tuition, student health insurance, but then the school switched health insurances, so I couldn't have gone even if I stuck with the school's tuition student insurance. So that's when I switched to Medicaid, but because it's still the same problem of I couldn't go to my appointment anyway. That's why I ultimately ended up not going. So, there was a two-to-three-week period where I realized that I had to either switch if I didn't want to pay the student health insurance again and they allowed me to, I mean I basically submitted like the confirmation that I applied to Medicaid instead of confirmation that I got Medicaid. So, there was like a two-to-three-week period where I wasn't covered while I was waiting for an acceptance from the plan that I chose.” (P658)

Those who were covered for less than 2 years were asked if there were any months between their current and previous coverage. In total, 10 participants said no while six respondents reported not having coverage during this time for the following durations in descending order: 1 year (P11 and P283), 6 months (P405), 4 months (P132), 1 month (P576), and 2 to 3 weeks (P658).

Others in Household

Participants were asked about the type of health coverage held by other people in their household. Some participants whose children lived with them answered that they were covered by the same health plan as the participant, as in the following example.

“We have a daughter, she is six years old. She is also covered under the same plan.” (P212)

Similarly, one said the following about their brother:

“My brother got the same coverage as me, he's the only one in my household.” (P108)

However, one participant who lived with their father did not know precisely what health coverage their father had.

“I do live with my father. He is a Vietnam veteran. He goes to the VA hospital for his medications that he needs. So, that's, I guess that's his health coverage right there. He's covered. He's got [D: Medical]. He's got, you know, other things. So, he's, he was in the services. So, that's, he's all covered.” (P132)

Those who had roommates who were not direct family members ranged in terms of their knowledge but were able to answer. The following participants were especially knowledgeable:

"My friend (name redacted) has Medicare and Medicaid because he's been disabled for (number of years redacted) and he has a...plan for secondary insurance company...United Healthcare, (inaudible) care, Care Plus, there's all these, they're companies that supply, the sign-up period just recently stopped on the [D]. Part C plan." (P313)

"I live with my girlfriend who is on Medicaid and then I have one roommate, I think she doesn't have healthcare as far as I know but she is starting a new job this month." (P445)

The following participants were less specific but were able to identify where others in their household received their insurance:

"One of my roommates, through his parents, the other two I believe are through their work." (P340)

"Well, my boyfriend has his health care through his job. I don't really know what he has, but I know his is through his job." (P549)

"My two roommates are also covered by their parents." (P718)

Several participants were not able to provide much detail about their roommates' coverage.

"Guess regular medical plans." (P359)

"My roommate just got laid off, so I don't think she has health insurance right now, but she had mentioned one that started with a C I think. I'm not too familiar with it." (P405)

"Well, to be honest with you, I only have one other person in my household and it's a gentleman that I rent a room to, so we don't really have a relationship where we discuss that. He's a part time (removed for potential PII), he's part time worker part time retired. So, I don't know what kind of coverage he has." (P417)

"I am not certain, but one of them has a full-time job with the city, so I'm assuming they probably have a health plan, and the other person I think works at two different places part-time, so he's probably not insured at all, I would guess." (P658)

One respondent did not know if their brother had coverage (P107).

Participants whose household members had the same health coverage were asked if these household members shared their plan or if they had their own. Participants who lived with family members typically reported sharing the same plan, while those that lived with roommates mentioned having their own. However, two participants who lived with direct family members (brother and father, respectively) shared that they each had their own plan.

Participants were asked how knowledgeable they felt about the coverage of others in their household when it was different from their own. In general, participants did not feel very knowledgeable about others' health coverage, except for one participant.

"I'm quite knowledgeable...a lot more than my own because he uses his a lot more because of his disability and he has more health issues... but I'm the one that makes most of his appointments and transportation..." (P313)

One participant said they were "just assuming" in terms of being knowledgeable about the health coverage of others in their household (P658). Another said they were not sure because their boyfriend does not typically get sick, so he has not had to seek medical help (P549). One participant said they felt somewhat knowledgeable about their girlfriend, mentioning what it covered and referring to copays or premiums, but were not at all knowledgeable about their roommate (P445).

"Not too much, I know she always talks about a \$50 copay. She'd be going to the doctor's a lot; I don't know too much about it." (P405)

"Not very knowledgeable, I know for a fact that one is under 26 and covered with parents, the other two I believe is probably through work as well." (P340)

Finally, participants were asked if there was anyone outside of the household who shared coverage with them or other people in the household. All respondents answered no, except one participant who was under 26 and on their parent's health plan and who lived with unrelated roommates who were also on their own parents' plans, although none of the parents lived in the shared household (P718).

Terminology

Participants were asked for their interpretation of four terms used in relation to health insurance. These terms were premium, subsidy, co-pay, and policyholder. Of the 25 participants who answered these questions, only 10 provided answers that were consistent with the intended meaning of health insurance premium. One of these included employer-paid portions of a premium, while others did not.

"A fee you pay per year for the insurance. Some Medicare plans have premiums." (P76)

"The price you pay every month." (P108)

"A premium is something on my health insurance, on my car insurance. It's basically paying a hefty amount to have full coverage." (P181)

"It's the total amount that is paid to the insurance company for coverage throughout the year, some of which is paid by us through my wife's paycheck, and the rest is paid by the employer." (P212)

"It's what's paid by somebody to their insurance company toward their healthcare." (P340)

"That's the amount you pay every month to keep the insurance." (P445)

Of the remaining 15, two said that they did not know what the term meant. Seven other participants thought it meant a payment the insured person makes but not as a fee to buy the coverage. Instead, they thought of it as related to the co-pay, the deductible, or the co-insurance or portions of medical bills that insurance does not cover and are the responsibility of the insured person.

"The premium is what you pay, what the insurance company doesn't cover, I think that's what that is." (P283)

"I Think a premium if I were to guess... I Think a premium might be like you have to spend that much money out of pocket before your insurance comes in. I think that's what it is. That sounds right. So, like say for instance, you have a \$1,000 premium on, I don't know, surgery. I think that would mean you'd have to spend yourself \$1,000 before your insurance comes in and I think sometimes your insurance will just completely start paying for it or I think they'll after that pay a percentage of it." (P658)

"A premium is something they do half and half I believe. You pay one half, and they pay one." [I: What do you mean they pay one half, and you pay one half? Is this like a monthly pay or a visit pay or what?] "A premium is a certain amount that they're assigned." (P549)

Six thought that premium refers to the quality of a health plan, in terms of how much coverage it offers. A premium plan would be a top or best plan, in their view.

"A premium means it's good, good stuff." [And a health insurance premium?]

"Yeah, that's the best one!" (P11)

"Good health plan. You get better quality care, you have access to better health, hospitals, doctors, to me." (P47)

"A premium would be like the best." [I: Okay, and in terms of health care coverage, again, what does premium mean?] "Premium in health care coverage would mean just like all-inclusive." (P132)

"The best type of plan for what you are looking for." (P620)

Subsidy was a term that most participants (13) could not define at all. Many of them had heard of the term but did not know what it meant. Another eight participants provided definitions that generally fell within the intended meaning.

"People who are in need, low income. Government provided healthcare." (P47)

"It's like, almost like a discount based on income. So, some form of assistance." (P76)

"I'm assuming it's a government funded or maybe privately funded amount, that is paid if one cannot afford more than a certain amount, maybe it would be paid from tax money or some sort of third party that would help cover the gap between what the person is paying and the amount of money that is necessary to complete the coverage." (P212)

The remaining four participants provided definitions that were not consistent with the intended meaning and reflected a misunderstanding of what a subsidy is or how it works.

"A subsidy, I guess it would be like secondary, a substitute, you know. Not the first, but maybe an alternative." (P132)

"That's a term used, for example, older people who are retired may get a subsidy check, like low-income individuals, for basic needs." [And in the context of health insurance what do you think it may mean?] "Health insurance is different because you get covered through the company." (P181)

"I'd say it's the portion that the employer picks up..." (P205)

"Subsidy I'm assuming it would be like partial coverage. Maybe not necessarily the copay but it could be that as well. Like you pay maybe half of your expenses." [I: And who would provide that subsidy?] "The insurance company." (P620)

When participants were asked to define the term co-pay, 16 could do so adequately because they were aware of the fixed fee they must pay at a medical appointment to receive services or at the pharmacy for their prescription medications.

"To me a copay means when you go to see a doctor you're paying a very small portion of that visit, so it might be \$10, \$20, if you see a specialist it's

usually more, it could be \$40 per visit so kind of depends on the coverage you have and the name of the insurer as to how much that copay will be but you're paying a small portion and then your insurance company is paying a larger portion which is maybe several hundred dollars." (P417)

"It's what it costs me to receive a certain medical health related service." (P332)

"Never thought about, it was just something they told me that I need to do to see a doctor. Which I don't understand it why we have to do a copay when there's an insurance that's already paid. So I never thought about it I just do it just to see a doctor." (P47)

"Just how much you owe at the time that you're at an office or wherever you are while everything else is getting figured out by insurance." (P405)

Six other participants appeared to confuse co-pays with co-insurance payments, deductibles, or out-of-pocket payments.

"Co-pay I mean it's just like wouldn't that be like a deductible or something like that?" (P107)

"A certain amount of money you are paying. Like doctor visits if someone has no insurance and has to pay out of pocket." (P181)

"To me, the co-pay is, they give you a price that you're supposed to pay, but they'll cut it in half. And then you pay one portion, and then your insurance pays the other portion." (P549)

"It's what the insurance company does not cover." (P620)

"Alright, we're going to pay this, but you have to pay this amount. We'll pay together. So, you're co-payers. You're both paying a portion of it. That would make you both co-payers, payors. So, co-payment would be my part and then the health insurance co-payment would be out of pocket." (P500)

"So let's say our deductible is \$5000. The first \$5000 of the calendar year we have to pay fully out of our own pocket. And if our maximum out of pocket is \$10,000, the additional \$5000 would be something like for the next 10 times you go, there's a cost of \$1000 each time, we would be paying \$500 each time and the insurance covers the difference, so we are co-paying with the insurance company to meet up to that maximum out of pocket." (P212)

Finally, the remaining three provided vague definitions that did not make it clear how they understood the term. They appeared to be trying to guess what the term may mean.

“Yeah, you just pay a little bit towards the bill.” (P56)

“I wanna say copay means portion of full payment.” (P175)

“I’m thinking that we got to split, like 50/50.” (P11)

With regard to the term policyholder, two participants said they did not know the term, while 18 others had a good understanding of who the term refers to. Some based it on who pays for the policy and others stressed whose name is the primary person in the insurance or through whom the insurance plan is obtained.

“The person who is paying for the health plan, health care.” (P47)

“The main person who has the coverage.” (P132)

“That’s the person, in this case my wife, whose name is the primary person.” (P340)

“Policyholder is probably like the main person on a plan because I’m like single and I have my own plan. I would be the policyholder, but if I was like a father and I had like two dependents, then I would be the policyholder and then the dependents would be like my kids.” (P658)

The other seven participants displayed uncertainty about the meaning of the term; even when they provided reasonable definitions, they second guessed themselves and appeared confused.

“My policy holder um, like policy holder was like the company or the insurance workers that was helping me out with my medication and my hospital visits and just getting checkups and stuff like that.” (P107)

“Someone has health insurance.” [In your case, who would be the policyholder?] “Blue Cross Blue Shield” (P181)

“Policyholder, I thought that would be me, but I guess is that the company? I don’t know.” (P283)

“That would be me. If I have a policy, I’m the policyholder. Or it could maybe, the underwriter of the policy, or the plans actually cover, your plan actually belongs to...you can have Geico but there’s other companies that underwrite Geico insurance plans in different parts of the country.” (P313)

“The person that is holding the, that has, like my doctor, right? That’s for medical people, right?” (P549)

Recommendations

As shown previously, several participants either did not know the meaning of the terms premium and subsidy or showed a mistaken understanding of the terms when putting them into their own words. For this reason, we recommend that definitions of the two terms be included when those terms are first used in a questionnaire. With regards to “health coverage,” “health plan,” and “health insurance” and given the substantial variation in the way participants viewed these as similar or different, we recommend using the term health insurance, which was most familiar and well understood by participants whenever possible, or that descriptions be used in place of these terms.

3.1.4 Alternative Methods of Collection

In this section, participants were asked to retrieve their insurance card to provide the interviewer information from the cards. Seven participants either said that they do not have a card or that they could not find it right then. All others produced the card and either the interviewer was able to see it on screen and record the information or the participant read it to the interviewer if it was not clear on screen.

Of the 18 participants who had the card with them, three were unable to find the name of their plan on the card, but 13 could answer what type of plan it was, whether HMO, HAS, PPO, or Medicaid.

Not all participants were knowledgeable about what their insurance plan covers or does not cover, and the information on the card was not great help. Many felt it covered everything, all types of medical needs.

“For everything. Dentist, eye doctor, the dudes that pop all your bones and that. For meds. They give you a Walgreens card as well.” (P11)

“Primary care specialist, telemedicine, urgent care, outpatient hospital, inpatient hospital, of course there’s different price to all that, emergency room.” (P47)

“Free emergency CareSource, urgent care and stuff around the city, that’s free, I have to get picked up by the ambulance, that’s free. Vision, they help me out with the vision and I’m not sure about what’s going on with dental.” (P108)

Four were unsure regarding coverage for dental, mental health, or vision. One participant specifically mentioned that cosmetic procedures were not covered.

“Pretty much everything. Though electives are not, cosmetic procedures. But all necessary things are covered, including prescriptions. It’s got pretty broad coverage... Dental is also covered.” (P76)

Participants were next asked how they would prefer to provide their health insurance information to Census Bureau. An introductory statement explained why it is important for Census Bureau to collect such information and why it can amount to a lot of questions to make sure the person's coverage is clear. For this section, participants were offered three hypothetical options for providing the information: (1) answering a lot of questions about their coverage, (2) inputting basic information from their insurance card, or (3) uploading a photo of their insurance cards.

Fifteen participants selected the option of uploading a photo of the card. They generally agreed that this preference was based on it being the easiest option.

"Just upload it and you don't have to do anything else. It's just quick and easy." [I: "would you have any concerns about uploading a picture?"] R: "There's always concerns anytime you do anything online, so I cannot be scared all the time. Cause I'm always concerned whenever you have to upload a driver's license or a social security for jobs and different things, but my husband works for [redacted] so my network is pretty secure, so I think it's pretty safe for now." (P47)

"Yes. It would be easier. Personally, I do think navigating healthcare can be very challenging. I have a master's degree and a bachelor's... it's hard. For everyday people, it's... whenever you have an issue you call your insurance company... Uploading a card would be easier for me." (P205)

"It's just a whole lot simpler. If they're taking the information they need just from the back of my insurance card, I don't mind the U.S. Census Bureau having a copy of that." (P313)

"It just makes it so that all the accurate information is taken from the picture and there's no confusion as to in case you put in the wrong information in the wrong box or fill out the wrong box." (P405)

"Because that's what I've done before, and it seems to be the easiest option." (P576)

Two participants selected the second option to input the basic information from their card. They felt this would be easier.

"Because if I got it right here now; that means it will be a little bit easier." (P108)

"That's how I would prefer to do it, it seems easier." (P340)

Eight participants selected the first option to answer a lot of questions about their coverage.

"That's how I would prefer to do it, it seems easier."

Their stated reasons varied from security concerns to information control and fear of technology.

“Because of security reasons, not wanting to upload or input my information somewhere.” (P76)

“The list of questions... I just feel like somebody is trying to infiltrate my information or something like that, I don’t know, it just feels wrong, something too wrong to ask.” [I: What feels wrong to ask?] R: “I don’t want to say wrong, I don’t know, that’s an inappropriate question to give someone like, I don’t know, I just don’t feel like, I don’t know, the feeling I just get, honestly a bad feeling, I don’t know.” [I: Regarding which question?] R: “Like asking, like somebody say what provider are you with right off the bat, I don’t think nobody gonna tell them, but they might tell you stuff about the plan, not who the plan is coming from you know. That’s why I would rather answer the questions (inaudible) just telling them I’m with such and such.” [I: You feel like it’s uncomfortable to give information about the name of the plan or upload a photo? Or both?] R: “Photo. Both, both, both, yeah.” (P175)

“Because it makes the process easier, sometimes with electronics you try to open this, and that becomes an issue, and then you spend more time. Quicker.” (P181)

“To me that one seems more secure in a way, like if I’m giving my ID number or showing my insurance card, I’m not sure how that information is getting stored so if it’s not used for something with a direct health benefit I guess then, that’s just not really something I feel comfortable floating out there.” (P445)

Recommendations

Participant preferences for how this information should be collected varied. Most participants either preferred uploading a photo of their ID card because of its ease or preferred to answer questions about their coverage because it felt more secure to them or gave them more control. A minority of participants preferred the option to input basic information from their card because it seemed easy. In light of this, we recommend that survey respondents be given the option to either answer a set of questions or to upload a photo of their insurance card, as those were the most preferred methods. This way both types of respondents will be served, and the information needed can be collected from the maximum number of respondents.

3.1.5 Cognitive Testing of Question Set A

Part two of the interview protocol shifted from open-ended discussion to a more focused discussion about specific questions. Participants were asked to answer a set of questions via a web survey and were probed about their answers after the first three questions and again after completing the rest of the question set. The first subset of questions were as follows.

Q1) Do you NOW have any type of health plan or health coverage?

- Yes
- No (DONE WITH QUESTION SERIES)

Q2) How do you get the coverage you have now?

- Through your job
- Through a spouse/partner or parent's job
- Government or state
- Some other way

Q3) Are you covered by any of the following? *Mark all that apply.*

- Medicare (for 65+ and people with disabilities)
- Medicaid, State Medicaid, Medical Assistance, or CHIP
- State exchange plan or other state health plan

If Q2 = Through your job or through a spouse/partner or parent's job, go to Q4

If Q2 = Government or state, go to Q5

If Q2 = Some other way, go to Q6

Deciding on coverage categories in questions 2 and 3 and confusion around 'Mark all that apply'

Twenty-three participants selected "yes" to question 1 and were subsequently asked questions 2 and 3. Participants were able to answer question 1 without any issues. Question 2 also seemed to be straightforward for most participants, but a few indicated that they selected their answers through a process of elimination.

"Just based off of the type that it was, and process of elimination also."
(P405)

"I know the coverage I'm getting is provided by the government. I know that; I can't give you any other reason why, since I'm not working, it's not through my job. I don't have a spouse or partner so, it's also some sort of process of elimination, but I just know that Medi-Cal and Medicaid are government, that's clearly what I have." (P417)

"Well, I knew it wasn't going to be my job because I don't have one really. And I knew it wasn't going to be a spouse, partner, or parents' job because none of those give me health insurance. Government or state because it's Medicaid and some other way I'm assuming is like a private personal insurance and that's not me either. So, government or state seem to be most descriptive." (P658)

Question 3 was generally more problematic for participants. One issue was that they thought they had to select one of the responses: it was not clear to some participants that they were not required to select any of the answers to the mark all that apply question if none of them applied to their situation. For example, one participant selected "Medicaid, State Medicaid, Medical Assistance, or CHIP" after selecting "Through your job" in question 2 and explained the following:

"I really don't know. I just chose the answer because I don't think I have any of them, can I choose not any of them? Do I have to choose one?" Later in the interview, at probing, this participant then changed their answer but still thought that they were required to select an answer, "I guess the best answer would be number 3 because I don't have Medicaid or Medicare but I do have coverage so I guess it would be state exchange plan, health plan." (P175)

Another participant seemed to misunderstand what was meant by "other state health plan" in question 3. This participant selected "Through your job" at question 2 went on to select selected "State exchange plan or other state health plan" at question 3.

"Because it's through my company and it is state, Blue Cross Blue Shield Florida, so state, Florida." (P181)

Another participant who had recently become covered under Medi-Cal, California's Medicaid program, mistakenly selected "State exchange plan or other state health plan" as their answer to question 3 but commented that they were not confident in their answer.

"Honestly that one's a little confusing, that potentially sounded correct, but not 100% sure." (P405)

Perhaps also because of confusion around believing that they needed to select an answer to question 3, two participants who selected "Through a spouse/partner or parent's job" at question 2 also selected "State exchange plan or other state health plan" at question 3. One of these participants was clear in their think-aloud that the selection was based on the other two response options clearly not applying to their situation.

"Since we don't have Medicare or Medicaid, it must be the third option."

In probing, this participant did not know what the state exchange plan option meant (P620). The other participant said of their partner's plan through their employer, "I think it's a

federal plan through the state,” which seemed to lead them to choosing “State exchange plan or other state health plan” in questions 3, but they may have believed they had to find an answer among the options provided.

Only one of the participants in our testing chose more than one option to question 3. This participant, who has Medicaid coverage, selected both “Medicaid, State Medicaid, Medical Assistance, or CHIP” and “State exchange plan or other state health plan.”

“Because I know I got it through the state, I know it’s Medicaid, I just figured the bottom two were the right ones and it says State Medicaid, Medical Assistance, State Exchange plan or state health plan. I know it’s through the state, so that’s why it’s called Keystone. I don’t know. That’s how I came up with it.” (P283)

Only five participants did not select any option for question 3, with think-alouds making clear that they understood that they did not need to select any answer if none applied to them. One participant even suggested that adding a “None of these” option to question 3 to make it clear for people who may believe they need to select an answer (P212).

Understanding of Questions 1–3

In probing, participants were also asked to explain in their own words what questions 1–3 are asking. Most participants were able to explain that the questions were generally asking about health coverage and the type of coverage that one has.

“Ok, first and second, do you know have any type of health coverage, it’s just plain and simple, yes or no. The second said how do you get the coverage; I mean these questions don’t give any type of subliminal messages. It’s pretty much asking what type of situation you in...do you got private insurance, you got health insurance, you got coverage?” (P108)

“They just want to know, like, what do you have that covers you when you're sick.” (P132)

“It’s asking who’s covering my health insurance, who’s paying for it, how am I getting the coverage.” (P417)

“They kind of start broad asking if you have any kind of coverage. The second is about what type. And the 3rd one is about any additional plans.” (P576)

Understanding of “Government or state” in Question 2

Participants were also asked to provide some examples of what might be included in the “government or state” category in question 2. Participants who were able to provide examples gave answers as the following:

“I would just think it’s Medicaid or Medicare.” (P76)

“Medicare, Medicaid, Medi-Cal, those ones would be government or state.”
(P405)

“Well, Medicare and Medicaid I think would be the two big ones. I’m assuming that if you’re enlisted in the military, they probably have some sort of health insurance.” (P658)

One participant, however, gave a more general definition of government aid.

“Government or state. Probably helping with like eating, food, you know, just minimum help, shelter probably as well.” (P132)

Additionally, five participants were unable to provide an example of what the “government or state” category in question 2 might mean.

No issues found with Question 4

Eleven participants selected either “Through your job” or “Through a spouse/partner or parent’s job” to question 2 and were therefore shown question 4.

Q4) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- Current job
- Former job (if retired)
- Union
- Spouse/partner or parent’s job
- TRICARE or TRICARE for Life
- Other Military coverage (specify)
- COBRA

Participants had no issues answering question 4. All four of the participants who selected “Through your job” for question 2, answered “Current job” to this question, and all seven participants who answered “Through a spouse/partner or parent’s job” answered “Spouse/partner or parent’s job” to this question. None reported any confusion or difficulty answering the question.

Question 5 and differentiating between types of Medicaid

Question 5, as shown below, was administered to participants, but no direct probes were asked during the interview.

Q5) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- Medicare (Parts A+B; Part C)
- Medicare Advantage

- Medicaid or Medical assistance
- State Medicaid program
- Through a state exchange or marketplace
- Indian Health Service
- Children’s Health Insurance Plan (CHIP)
- Veterans Administration Coverage (VA Care, CHAMPVA)
- Other Military coverage, specify: _____
- Another government plan, specify: _____

In later probing, one participant said they found question 5 difficult to answer and said it was because of the inclusion of two response options that mention “Medicaid.”

“That one was a little confusing because it says State Medicaid Program and Medicaid or Medical Assistance.” [I: How do you see the differences between the two?] “I don’t and that’s why it makes me confused.” (P76)

“Some other way” and questions 6 & 7

Only one participant selected “Some other way” as their answer to question 2 and was therefore the only participant asked question 6, as shown below.

Q6) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- Purchased directly from an insurance company or on the exchange or a marketplace
- Union
- Group or association, other than a union
- School
- Some other way, specify: _____

This participant again answered “Some other way” but did not provide a more specific write-in.

“I was contacted by e-mail and then a phone call and we discussed the insurance plan, and I told them my expected income and how much I earned that year and the year before and what my expected income for this year 2023, and the lady signed me up for the silver plan Ambetter through Sunshine Health.” (P313)

It is difficult to know what type of plan this participant has because they did not seem very clear about it themselves. They may have a marketplace plan, but they did not see the option for “State exchange plan or other state health plan” in question 3 because they answered “Some other way” to question 2. Because they selected “Some other way” to question 6, they were shown question 7 below. This participant chose “Health insurance from a company online or through a broker” for question 7.

Q7) (If Q6= Some other way) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- Health insurance exchange or a marketplace, like healthcare.gov
- Health insurance from a company online or through a broker
- Union
- Group or association, other than a union
- School
- Some other way, specify: _____

Questions 8 & 9

Because of skip patterns, none of our participants were asked questions 8 or 9 and were not probed on them.

Ease of answering the questions

Overall, most participants said they found the questions in question set A easy to answer. All 11 participants who answered “Through your job” or “Through a spouse/partner or parent’s job” to question 2 said that they found these questions easy to answer. Among the 11 participants who answered “Government or state” to question 2, six said that they found these questions easy to answer.

Additionally, three participants commented that while the questions were not difficult to answer, they were not confident in their answers.

“It’s easy, they’re easy to answer. I don’t know if they’re the right ones (answers)... It would be 50-50...Because I really don’t know... much about this subject.” (P283)

“They were easy for me to answer...Um, I’m going to say like 6-7 out of 10. 6-7, 8, that range...Um, well not 10 because I got Medicare and Medicaid confused before. Um, so, um, that’s the main reason, not 10. But I mean, the only reason I knew there was a difference between all Medicaid and state exchange programs is just because, like I’m a law student and I read about court cases that were states suing the government over Medicaid and trying to opt out. So that’s the only reason I know there’s a difference. But if not for that, I wouldn’t know what the difference was between your state and state plan instead of Medicaid plan.” (P658)

As discussed previously, one participant also said they found question 5 difficult to answer because it includes multiple response options that included the word “Medicaid” when it was unclear to the participant what the difference between “Medicaid or Medical assistance” and “State Medicaid program” might be.

Questions and terms that caused confusion

Participants were also asked if any words in the questions were confusing to them or if they thought any might be difficult for others to understand. Two participants said that they found the phrasing of the question “How did you get the coverage you have now?” to be confusing. One participant seemed to be thinking about the process for obtaining the coverages, as opposed to the source of the coverage.

“No, just the way it's questioning... I think that's the only confusing part, is the way, because it's not really quality. It's not really saying something specific. It's just saying, how did you get your coverage?” (P56)

“How did you get the coverage you have now? I wouldn't think of those things for answering that question. I think about like what you said before, how did you get it? Did you fill out an application? Did you go to online? I actually have to fill out my application and I'm not qualified for Medicare.” (P500)

Participants also named other terms as concepts they were not sure about or that others might not understand. Four participants said they were not familiar with “TRICARE.” Two said they were not familiar with “COBRA.” One participant did not know what an “insurance exchange” was, and one said that others may not understand the difference between with “Medicare A, B, and C” and “Medicare Advantage.”

Participants were also asked if there were any options missing from these questions. Most said there were not, but a few suggested other possible options.

“I thought of one other way to do medical coverage is if you volunteer for the experiments and such, trying to get them, trying to get like certain drugs passed. You know what I mean? Like our, like we want to do new headache medicine. We need 80 volunteers. They get your medication at that time, and they give you a reasonable checkup just to make sure that you fit in. So that's kind of coverage. But you're grasping at straws. You're grasping at straws.” (P500)

“I think there are like some collectives out there, I don't know if that's the technical term they use, but it's like a plan you buy into with a bunch of other people. I know there's like one for one that's geared towards Christians. That maybe people in ministry. I'm not sure If it's specific to ministry or not, but you buy in, I mean it works very similar to the basic, basic, and original concept of insurance where everybody pools money in, and it's used when needed. It's not big corporation, it's individuals that are coming together to have that health plan.” (P332)

Another participant who was on Medicaid and so did not see question 4, which included “Union” as a response option, suggested a “Union” option be added.

“I guess if you want to be as descriptive as possible, I guess some other way could be broken into, like, through your union, with like parentheses, not your employer, your union, and then I guess you could also do personal private plan, and then you could use some other way. I don't know what other ways there are on top of that, but at least it gives you two more options that might apply to some more people.”

Recommendations

This testing made clear that some participants did not realize that they could select none of the response options to question 3 if none applied to them. As discussed previously, only five participants did not select any option for question 3, and participant think-aloud feedback made clear that they did not understand that they did not need to make a selection and felt compelled to choose from the options offered. To mitigate this issues, we recommend that a “None of the above” option be added to question 3.

Question 3 recommended alternative

Q3) Are you covered by any of the following? *Mark all that apply.*

- Medicare (for 65+ and people with disabilities)
- Medicaid, State Medicaid, Medical Assistance, or CHIP
- State exchange plan or other state health plan
- None of the above

3.2 Income

This section presents results and recommendations where appropriate for ASEC Income questions by topic area. Within each section, participants were first asked exploratory questions to gather general information about that topic area. All participants were then asked to complete ASEC questions for each of these topic areas, and corresponding follow-up probes were then administered to better understand participant responses and understanding of draft ASEC questions.

In addition to sources of income, participants were also asked to answer ASEC questions about different types of programs and expenses, including free or reduced-price school meals, WIC and SNAP participation, participation in energy assistance and housing programs, medical expenses, and childcare expenses. For each domain in this section, general findings from exploratory questions are presented first, where applicable, followed by question specific findings.

3.2.1 General Income

At the beginning of each interview, participants were asked a series of questions to determine how they “make or receive money” prior to being shown the question 1 list of potential income sources. Eleven participants reported being employed; three reported being unemployed; four reported doing some form of consulting, contract, or freelance work; four reported being business owners; seven reported receiving income from Social Security or Supplemental Security Income (SSI), six reported income from retirement accounts or company pensions; and two reported income from interest or dividends. Ten participants reported only one source of income, with 15 reporting income from more than once source during this initial probing. Responses to this initial probe are presented in **Table 3.1**.

Table 3.1. How Participants “Make or receive money”

Open-End Reporting (Prior to Q1)	Count
Employed	11
Consulting, Contract, or freelance	4
Owns Business	4
Social Security	7
Retirement or pensions	6
Unemployed	3
Interest and Dividends	2

When asked about “any other sources of income” they received seven participants reported other sources of income. Four participants also reported receiving money from “side jobs,” such as landscaping/lawn maintenance, pool cleaning, pet sitting, and food delivery (i.e., DoorDash and Instacart). Three of these participants (P138, P55, P279) reported being employed (i.e., income from wages), and one considered themselves unemployed (P54). Three additional participants (P48, P2, P363) also reported receiving money from participating in studies (e.g., surveys, focus groups) and one (P52) from online product reviews.

Participants were then asked to respond to question 1 and select all the sources of income they currently receive, as shown below.

Q1) Sources of income received:

- o Wages or salary
- o Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice
- o Income from your own farm
- o Social Security or Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
- o Unemployment compensation

- o Interest on savings, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts, and so on
- o Dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on
- o Pensions and company retirement
- o Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on)
- o Public assistance or welfare
- o Rental properties, estates or trusts

In Q1, 15 participants selected “Wages and salary,” five reported “Income from your own nonfarm business...,” seven selected “Social Security or Supplemental Security Income (SSI),” two reported receiving “Unemployment compensation,” eight reported “Interest on savings, CDs, bonds...,” eight reported “Dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on,” seven reported “Pensions and company retirement,” two reported “Withdrawals from retirement accounts,” three reported “Public assistance or welfare,” and one Reported “rental properties, estates, or trusts.” No participants selected “Income from your own farm.” Responses to Question 1 are presented in **Table 3.2**.

Table 3.2. Responses to Question 1

Q1 Response	Count
Wages and salary	15
Interest on savings, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts and so on	8
Dividends on stocks, mutual funds and so on	8
Social Security or Supplemental Security Income (SSI)	7
Pensions and company retirement	7
Withdrawals from retirement accounts	2
Income from your own nonfarm business	4
Public assistance or welfare	3
Unemployment compensation	2
Rental properties, estates, or trusts	1
Income from your own farm	0

When responding to Question 1, seven participants reported only source of income, with 15 reporting multiple sources of income from the list. Not surprisingly, of those who reported having income from Social Security, four also reported receiving income from retirement or pensions (P151, P180, P211, P220). Two participants (P599, P496) reported being employed but also doing freelance, consulting, or contract type work outside of their primary job. Similarly, one participant (P28) reported being employed full time and running a small business; another (P1) reported working part-time in addition to being a business owner as their primary job. One participant (P180) reported retirement income but also occasionally doing consulting work for additional income, and one (P90) reported working

full time in addition to receiving a pension. Several participants also reported some form of interest or dividends in addition to having other sources of income.

Although the majority of participants selected responses in Q1 that aligned with the income sources they mentioned in initial probing, some participants selected income sources in Q1 that they did not initially consider when first asked about how they made or receive money. This indicates that the set of responses in Q1 elicited a more complete list of income sources than an open-ended approach. Eight selected “Interest on savings, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts, and so on” and eight selected “Dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on” after seeing the Q1 list (10 total, as response options were not mutually exclusive), but only two (P506, P372) had initially considered their income from interest and dividends when initially probed about income sources. One participant (P496) also reported income from “Rental properties, estates, or trusts” and described this as a “family trust for rental properties” but did not initially mention this income before seeing the Q1 list.

One participant (P54) who initially reported being unemployed and doing “side work” subsequently selected “Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice” in Q1. This participant explained that while they have a registered business for tax purposes and this is income from that business, they do not make enough to support themselves or file taxes on this income. Four additional participants (P1, P28, P507, P364) reported “Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice,” but all had initially reported having some type of business when first probed before Q1.

Participants were then asked if there was anything confusing about Q1. Two participants (P52, P506) who reported being currently unemployed in initial probing selected “Wages or salary” for income they had received previously in 2023 and noted they were uncertain about the timeframe they should report on because it was not included in the question. Two participants (P52, P151) were uncertain about the difference between “Pensions and company retirement” and “Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on).” Two participants (P507, P28) who reported being business owners also felt the term “nonfarm business” was confusing in the second response option.

Two participants (P507, P151) also felt it was not clear what should be considered under “Wages or salary.” One noted that pensions or social security could be considered wages and felt “wages or salary from employment” may be clearer. Two additional participants (P180, P48) selected “Wages or salary” for the independent consulting/contract work they described in initial probing. Similarly, one participant felt “Wages or salary” was specific to wages from employment, but it was unclear as written.

“Because I own a small business, when I hear salary or wages I think of someone else as the boss. So that part is a little unclear.” (P507)

3.2.2 Self-employment Income

In this section, participants were first asked to describe their job or other work they do for pay. Responses to this probe generally overlapped with answers provided in the “General Income” section where participants were asked to describe how they made or receive money. The 11 participants who reported being employed in Q1 reported working in a variety of different jobs and industries, such as transportation, wireless sales, warehouse shipping, package delivery, technology, accounting, insurance claims processing, and other services. Four participants reiterated that they owned their own businesses, including general contracting, hair braiding, online book sales, and vending sales. Four participants noted they did consulting, contracting, or freelancing work. One of these participants described their primary job as contracting through an agency that connects them with clients that need virtual assistants, another retired participant noted they did occasional consulting in the automotive industry, one employed participant reported consulting as an architect in addition to their primary job, and another employed participant noted they also did freelance work through Fiverr in addition to their primary job.

Participants were then probed to get a sense of any work they might do “on the side in addition to primary income.” As noted previously, four participants had already indicated they do “side work,” including landscaping/lawn maintenance, pool cleaning, DoorDash and Instacart, pet sitting; and three noted they participated in studies for pay; and one did online product reviews. One additional participant noted they sometimes do home maintenance for small amounts of money for friends and family, which they initially did not consider when describing work they do for pay under Q1 given the amount of money they make is typically small.

“I would say yes and that’s under \$500. I help family and friends with electrical issues, and they don’t like it when I don’t charge them, so I have to take something from them.” (P211)

Participants were then asked to review the Q2 list shown below and select any additional sources of income.

Q2) List:

- Babysitting or childcare
- Hair, beauty, or other personal care services
- Direct sales programs like Avon, Scentsy, Herbalife, or doTERRA
- Landscaping
- Delivery services like Instacart, DoorDash, or Uber Eats
- Other app-based jobs like Uber or Lyft
- Selling handmade items, in person or online on sites like Etsy
- Re-selling items, in person or online on sites like eBay

- Responding to surveys online for money
- Social media-related income, such as sponsored posts, YouTube video views, or streaming subscriptions
- Other services paid for in cash or via an app like Venmo or Cash App

Although only seven participants initially reported “Other work for pay” during earlier probing, 21 participants selected a response in Q2. It is noted, however, that all participants who initially indicated they did “other work for pay” through earlier probing during Q1 did report that work somewhere in Q2. Four participants did not select any additional sources of income in Q2. Fifteen participants selected “Responding to surveys online for money,” six selected “Other services paid in cash or via an app like Venmo or Cash App,” three selected “Landscaping,” two selected “Babysitting or childcare,” two selected “Re-selling items, in person or online...,” and there was one selection each for “Social media related income, such as sponsored posts...,” “Hair, beauty, or other personal care services,” “Delivery services like Instacart, DoorDash, or Uber Eats,” and “Selling handmade items, in person or online...” “Responding to surveys online for money” was by far the most selected response, but only three of these participants (P48, P2, P363) previously mentioned this income when initially probed about income sources in Q1. Responses to Question 2 are presented in **Table 3.3**.

Table 3.3. Responses to Question 2

Q2 Response	Count
Responding to surveys online	15
Other services paid in cash or via an app	6
Landscaping	3
Babysitting or childcare	2
Re-selling items in-person or online	2
Social media related income	1
Hair, beauty, or other personal care services	1
Delivery services like Instacart, DoorDash, or Uber Eats	1
Selling handmade items in-person or online	1

The six participants who selected “Other services paid in cash or via an app like Venmo or Cash App” described a variety of different tasks and jobs. One participant (P46) noted they selected this option because they sometimes participate in focus groups but, although similar, felt like “responding to surveys online” did not apply. Two participants who selected this option reported doing work for family or friends on occasion; one participant (P211) does maintenance type jobs for small amounts of cash, and another (P55) helps a family member with their business and is paid in cash. Two participants (P496, P599) who previously reported doing contract and freelance work selected this option to represent how

they are paid (i.e., paid via digital payment like Venmo, Cash App, PayPal); one of these participants (P496) also endorsed “wages” in Q1 to describe this same work. One participant (P54) selected both “other services paid for in cash...” and “landscaping” because as part of their landscaping “side work” they also occasionally do work with decks/pergolas but felt that work would not be reflected if they just selected “landscaping” (this participant also endorsed owning a business in Q1).

Two additional participants also selected “landscaping”; one participant (P1) who owns their own general contracting business and reported being a business owner in Q1 selected this option because general contracting sometimes includes landscaping, but they were reporting about the same business enterprise reported in Q1 when they selected “income from a nonfarm business....” Another participant (P138) cuts grass during the summer months for money on the side in addition to their primary employment.

One participant selected “Social media related income, such as sponsored posts...” because they do reviews for companies and receive payment in exchange for these reviews.

One participant (P363) who described having a hair braiding business and selected “Income from a business...” in Q1 also selected “Hair, beauty, or other personal care services” in Q2 to represent this same work.

Note that some duplicate reporting of sources of income occurred across Q1 and Q2 for four participants (P363, P54, P1, P496). As described previously, two participants (P1, P54) reported “Income from nonfarm business...” in Q1 but also selected “Landscaping” in Q2 because their businesses include this type of work. One of these participants (P54) also selected “Other services paid for in cash...” to represent the occasional deck/pergola construction they did as part of the same landscaping business (i.e., selected two options to represent the same income source). Another participant selected “Income from nonfarm business...” in Q1 and “Hair, beauty, or other personal care services” in Q2 to represent the same income source, since their business is in the hair and beauty field. These participants are selecting options from Q2 to represent primary sources of income.

Two participants (P52, P363) selected “Babysitting or childcare,” and reported being paid in cash, but neither had not previously mentioned this work when asked about all their sources of income.

Two participants (P420, P507) who reported “Re-selling items, in person or online...” indicated they re-sold their own items (e.g., clothing, household items) that they no longer needed. However, both participants were uncertain whether they should count this type of income.

“I do resell things, but it is mostly stuff that I am reselling own my own, like on Marketplace. What about if I am just reselling my own personal clothing I

don't wear anymore? When I hear re-sale, I think of more casual and not a structured business." (P507)

"Well, I would choose it, but I guess it depends like what you would consider income...I just do it during spring cleaning which is twice a year. [I don't consider it income] because I only do it twice a year." (P420)

One participant who does pet sitting was not sure what option in Q2 to select to represent that work, so they did not report it anywhere in Q2.

"Maybe it would go on the first page that asked about businesses (Q1), but as a person who tries to be accurate, I wouldn't know if I answered it right or not. And then I think maybe I should just click [baby sitting and childcare], but it is very obviously about nannying or babysitting jobs." (P507)

Finally, participants were asked if they considered themselves to be self-employed or an independent contractor. Four participants considered themselves to be independent contractors but not self-employed. One participant (P48) noted they would consider their job a "sole proprietorship" and themselves an independent contractor. Another participant (P599) felt their freelance work via Fiverr fell under independent contractor, and one participant (P279) similarly felt their work for DoorDash and Instacart fell under independent contractor. A final participant (P496) described working as a consultant architect and noted because they receive a 1099 and "control" their own work, they are an independent contractor.

"In my case if I am doing projects, it is my equipment. As an architect planner I provide all the services so [the clients] don't control me. Once they start to control me it qualifies as being an employee. I work as an independent contractor as a consulting architect." (P496)

Five participants considered themselves to be self-employed and described a variety of business ventures. One participant (P1) reported owning a general contracting company, another participant (P28) owns a small vending business, one participant (P507) sells books online, and another (P363) has a hair braiding business. One participant (P180) who works as a consultant considers themselves to be self-employed because they receive a 1099. However, this participant noted the companies they work for may also classify them as a contractor:

"It's a 1099, so that would be self-employed contractor. Tax wise I am self-employed; the auto part manufacturers I represent see me as a contractor."

When reflecting on responses to Q1, participants who selected "Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice" primarily considered themselves "self-employed," whereas those who described doing contract, consulting, or freelance work

in Q1 probing tended to consider themselves “independent contractors.” Of the five who selected “Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice” in Q1, four considered themselves to be “self-employed,” with two (P28, P1) considering themselves both “self-employed” and “employed” because they own businesses in addition to other employment. One participant (P54) who initially described their work as “side work” but indicated they receive money from a business in Q1 later noted in Q2 probing they did not consider themselves self-employed because they did not make enough money to support themselves through that work.

“I would if I made more money. I think there is a threshold. My intention is to eventually become self-employed, but at this time (what I am doing) I consider what I’m doing side jobs because there just isn’t enough of it and I am not doing enough jobs that I’d be comfortable considering myself self-employed. To me when you tell someone you’re self-employed, the image that comes to mind is that you are making enough self-employment monies to support yourself and that does not describe me at all.” (P54)

Participants who considered themselves “independent contractors” provided a variety of responses in Q1 and Q2. One independent contractor (P48) selected “Wages and salary” in Q1 to represent their income from contract work. One employed participant (P279) reported “wages and salary” in Q1 and “delivery services” in Q2 because they are employed by a company but also do DoorDash/Instacart on the side. Similarly, two participants (P496, P599) selected “wages and salary” in Q1 because they are employed full time but also selected “Other services paid in cash or via an app like Venmo or Cash App” in Q2 for their independent contract work because they are paid via these apps.

3.2.3 Retirement Income

Eight participants endorsed receiving income from “Pensions and company retirement” or “Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on)” in Q1 and were first probed to gather general information about the type of accounts, the frequency they receive that income, and the amount they receive.

One participant (P52) who is not retired or of retirement age and who selected “Withdrawals from retirement accounts” noted earlier in the interview they took a hardship withdrawal from their 401k early after being laid off and needing income. One participant (P496) reported “pensions and company retirement” in Question 1 but confirmed in Question 6 that they were not actively withdrawing from this benefit and clarified this was a 401k they have through their employer. Related, one participant (P151) endorsed both “Pensions” and “Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on),” but this participant shared they only receive a 403b, so they should not have selected the “pension” response. The other six participants were of retirement age and confirmed they were currently receiving income from a variety of different types of accounts, with four

describing company pensions, one receiving union pensions, and two noting they had an annuity. All of these participants noted they received their retirement pay on a monthly basis.

Next, participants who were of retirement age (65+) but did not mention income from retirement or pensions were probed to understand if their former or current employers offered any kind of retirement or pension benefits and whether they expect to receive this type of income in the future. Only two participants (P46, P2) were 65+ but did not mention this type of income in Q1. Both participants noted that none of their prior jobs offered retirement benefits, and both currently receive only Social Security.

All participants were then asked to respond to Q3–Q8, which asks about various sources of retirement income, as shown below.

Q3) During 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive any pension income from a previous employer or union, other than Social Security or VA benefits? *Do not include distributions or withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.*

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Q4) (IF YES TO Q3)¹: What was the source of the pension income? *Select all that apply.*

- ☐ Company
- ☐ Union
- ☐ Federal government
- ☐ State government
- ☐ Local government
- ☐ U.S. military
- ☐ U.S. Railroad Retirement pension
- ☐ Some other source, specify: _____

Q5) During 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive any income from an annuity?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Q6) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household have any retirement accounts such as a 401(k), 403(b), IRA, or another account designed specifically for retirement savings?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

¹ Text in parentheses indicates skip logic.

Q7) (IF YES to Q6): What type of retirement account? Select all that apply.

- 401(k)
- 403(b)
- Roth IRA
- Regular IRA
- KEOGH plan
- Simplified Employee Pension (SEP plan)
- Another type of retirement account, specify: _____

Q8) Did you or anyone in your household withdraw any money or receive a distribution from a [LIST ALL SELECTED IN PRIOR QUESTION] in 2022, including any distributions that may have been required to take?

- Yes
- No

Twenty participants responded “No” to Q3, with five participants responding “Yes.” The five participants who responded “Yes” to Q3 all previously reported pension income in Q1. Four of these participants indicated these were “company” pensions in Q4. One participant (P211) selected “Union,” which aligned with what they had previously reported in exploratory probing. As noted previously, however, one of these participants (P151) endorsed “pensions” in Q1 and Q3 but noted they had a 403b. Two participants (P220, P496) who reported “pension” income in Q1 responded “No” to Q3, with both indicating they have their retirement in an annuity (i.e., “Yes” to Q5). One additional participant (P151) also noted they received income from an annuity in 2022.

Fourteen participants indicated they had retirement accounts in Q6. These participants were then shown Q7 and asked to select the type of retirement accounts they were responding about in Q6. Of the fourteen who responded “Yes” in Q6, eleven selected “401(k),” one selected “403(b),” seven selected “Roth IRA,” four selected “Regular IRA,” one selected “Simplified Employee Pension,” and three selected “Another type of retirement account” (specifying “Hybrid SEP” and “Pension”) in Q7. Note that one participant selected “Another type of retirement account” potentially in error because they had withdrawn their 401(k) and reinvested that into non-retirement investment accounts (e.g., stocks).

Participants who endorsed retirement accounts in Q7 were then asked if anyone in the household withdrew from those accounts in Q8. Twelve participants indicated in Q8 that they, or someone in their household, had retirement accounts but were not currently withdrawing from them. Only two participants selected “Yes” to Q8, indicating they had withdrawn from the retirement plans they reported in Q7 in 2022. One participant (P52) noted they took an early 401(k) hardship withdrawal, which they had previously reported as a source of income in Q1. The other participant (P151) explained the “pension plan” they

receive payments from a 403(b), and they also withdraw from a Roth IRA. As noted previously, this participant selected “Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on)” and “Pensions and company retirement” in Q1 for their 403b and annuity.

Participants were then asked if there was anything that was confusing about Q3–Q8, or if there were any terms that were confusing to them. The majority of participants did not report anything confusing in this set of questions, but eight participants noted some form of confusion with terminology. Four participants noted they were not familiar with the term “annuity” and thought it might cause confusion. Three participants indicated they were uncertain about IRAs, with one noting they did not know the difference between a Roth IRA and a regular IRA. One participant reported being unfamiliar with 403(b) accounts. One participant suggested including information bubbles or hyperlinks that provide more information about these types of accounts. As detailed previously, two participants also endorsed “pensions” in Q1 when they were thinking about annuities, and one endorsed “pensions” in Q1 and Q3 for their 403b.

3.2.4 Public Assistance

Participants who endorsed receiving “public assistance or welfare” in Q1 as one of their sources of income were first probed to gather general information about the type of assistance, the frequency they receive the benefit, and the amount they receive. Three participants (P2, P52, P54) selected the “Public assistance or welfare” option in Q1. When probed on the type of assistance received, two participants (P2, P54) indicated they received SNAP, with one participant (P52) indicating they received both SNAP and “Section 8” housing assistance.

All three participants reported receiving SNAP benefits once a month. The participant who endorsed housing assistance noted 70% of their housing costs were paid directly to their landlord each month. Two of the SNAP recipients were able to provide the amount they received monthly (\$220, \$148); the final participant did not provide an amount, but noted the amount was based on their family size and number of child dependents.

All participants were then asked to respond to two different versions of the ASEC public assistance question, as shown below.

Q9 (Version 1)	Q10 (Version 2)
At any time during 2022, even for one month, did you or anyone in this household receive any CASH assistance from a state or county welfare program? ○ Yes ○ No	At any time during 2022, even for one month, did you or anyone in this household receive any CASH assistance from a state or county welfare program? INCLUDE: ○ Welfare or welfare to work ○ Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)/Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC) ○ General assistance ○ Diversion payments ○ Refugee cash ○ General assistance from Indian Affairs Do NOT include: ○ Food stamps or Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) benefits ○ Supplemental Security Income (SSI) ○ Energy assistance ○ Women, Infants and Children (WIC) ○ School meals ○ Childcare ○ Education assistance

Only one respondent (P2) selected “Yes” to Q9 and indicated they responded “Yes” because they receive SNAP food benefits. This same participant also endorsed “Public assistance or welfare” in Q1. However, after receiving the Q10 version of this question the participant acknowledged they misread Q9 and should have responded “No” because SNAP is not a “cash” benefit. The other two participants that endorsed “public assistance or welfare” in Q1 and reported receiving SNAP selected “No” to this item.

All participants were then asked what kinds of assistance they felt Q9 was asking about. Participants provided a variety of responses, with some identifying cash assistance programs like TANF and Welfare to Work, with others including non-cash programs like SNAP/food stamps, Medicaid, WIC, housing assistance, and daycare assistance that should not be included.

Three participants provided TANF as an example of a “cash” assistance.

“Cash assistance, welfare assistance. I think the correct term is TANF.”
(P399)

“This would include Welfare or Welfare to Work, TANF.” (P372)

Seven participants said “SNAP” or “food stamps” would be included, with three participants indicating “WIC” would be included.

“[It’s asking about] any kind of welfare program like SNAP or Medicaid, Food stamps, or WIC.” (P48)

“The only thing that I can think of, that comes to mind, would be like EBT cards.” (P28)

“Food stamps or the likes of that.” (P211)

“Money given towards daycare costs, or SNAP, or WIC. A cash stipend someone gets for something.” (P507)

Related, one participant (P279) first noted this would include any type of government assistance program but then indicated they did not initially notice the question was only asking about “cash” programs.

“Anything, any government program. Food stamps, housing assistance, health care. But says cash assistance, I guess like food help can get cash assistance. I didn’t pay attention to the CASH part, just any assistance program.” (P279)

Only one participant (P599) responded “Yes” to Q10 in error as they explained the “general assistance” they received was money family members provide on occasion. This participant responded “No” to Q9 and first selected “No” to Q10 but changed their response after reading “General assistance” in the bulleted list. This participant noted they were interpreting money received from family or friends as “General assistance.” Another participant (P48) also was uncertain if this could mean money from a family member.

“General assistance - does that mean money from a family member?” (P48)

When participants were asked if any of the examples in the include/do not include list in Q10 were confusing, four participants said they were confused by the term “general assistance” and noted the term was “vague” or “broad,” eight participants were uncertain about the meaning of “diversion payments,” and four participants were confused by the term “refugee payments.”

“General assistance is confusing and too vague. This could mean anything.”
(P507)

"General assistance is very broad. There are a lot of things that could go in that category." (P52)

"Diversion payments, I have no idea what that is. I've never heard of that. Refugee cash, never heard of that. General assistance from Indian Affairs, no idea what that would be." (P180)

"I'm not familiar with a diversion payment, I don't know what that term means. Everything else I understand." (P211)"

"I don't know what refugee cash is, just know it doesn't have anything to do with me. I also don't know what diversion payments are." (P506)

One respondent (P8) who lives in a group home setting with unrelated individuals indicated they were uncertain if anyone else in their home received these benefits and noted they did not consider the other individuals they lived with in their responses to Q9 and Q10.

Recommendations

When probed about what should be included in Q9 prior to seeing the bulleted lists provided in Q10, about half of respondents either included non-cash benefits or were not certain what should be considered when responding. We recommend including the include/do not include list in Q10 to mitigate misreporting, but clarifying the terms "general assistance," "diversion payments," and "refugee payments."

3.2.5 Income from Interest and Dividends

Of the 25 participants, ten reported receiving income from "interest on savings, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts, and so on" and income from "dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on" when responding to Q1. These participants were first probed to gather information about the types of account(s) that they have, the income they receive from these account(s), how they receive it, how frequently they receive it, and how much they receive.

Several participants had more than one type of account, with six participants having stocks, six having interest-earning checking or savings accounts, four having CDs, three having bonds, and one having mutual funds. When asked to explain more about this income, many participants specifically mentioned paying taxes on interest and dividends, noting that they must report income from these accounts when they file taxes.

"I own some individual stocks and I must pay taxes on any gains that they have. In addition to that I have mutual funds and I must pay taxes on any gains that they have." (P372)

"If you are buying and selling stocks you will have capital gains and losses...I have amassed a little tax loss carryforward as far as what you can deduct from your ordinary income every year going forward." (P90)

When asked what they receive, two participants reported receiving only nominal amounts of interest on their interest-earning checking or savings account(s), with neither reporting they withdrew these funds. Two indicated that the dividends that they receive on stocks are reinvested into more stocks; one received stock dividends four times a year, and one received dividends from mutual funds four times a year. Participants with interest-earning checking or savings accounts explained that they accrue interest monthly in their bank accounts. Participants with stocks received dividends quarterly; one of these participants received dividends from a brokerage firm while another puts the dividends from stocks into their checking account. Participants with CDs reported receiving dividends once a year, and the one participant with a mutual fund receives two paper checks from their mutual funds quarterly. Most participants reported that they did not receive substantial amounts of income from these accounts, totaling \$100 or less.

All participants were then asked to respond to Q11, which asks if they, or any member of their household, have money in several different types of accounts, as shown below.

Q11) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household have money in any of the following? Select all that apply.

- Interest-earning checking account
- Savings account
- Money market fund
- Certificates of deposits (CDs)
- Savings bonds
- Shares of stock in corporations or mutual funds
- Any other savings or investment that pay interest or dividends, specify:

Nineteen participants reported having this income in Q11, and six participants did not report having these types of accounts. Of the 10 participants who indicated one of these types of incomes in Q1, all reported these accounts when responding to Q11. Two participants (P599, P211) reported having several of these accounts but did not initially report this income when responding to Q1. One participant (P8) did not select any of the responses but indicated that they had an interest-earning checking account upon further probing. Some participants selected having an interest-earning checking account or savings account in Q11 but did not report this income in Q1. When probed further, most of these participants reported having a regular checking or savings account that does not accrue interest or generate income, or only generates nominal amounts.

“It was a simple savings account.” (P399)

“Just a regular checking account with Chase and Bank of America. I have savings account with Frost.” (P28)

Participants who indicated that they have money in one or more of the accounts were then asked what types of accounts they have. Several of the participants who reported income from these accounts selected one or more types of accounts. Five reported shares of stocks in corporations or mutual funds, three reported Certificates of deposits (CDs), seven reported interest-earning checking accounts or savings accounts, two reported savings bonds, one reported mutual funds, and one reported a money market fund. The two participants who did not report this income in Q1 indicated that they have an interest-earning checking account and savings account (P599) and a money market fund and stocks (P211).

Of the 19 participants that reported having one or more of these accounts, 12 participants confirmed that their accounts generate income. One participant receives \$100 from a CD, and one participant receives \$600 every 6 months from a CD. However, most participants who had accounts that generated interest reported receiving very little income (i.e., \$20 or less) or were not aware of how much interest they receive. One participant (P507) also explained that they do not consider the amount received to really be “income” because they do not use the money, they just reinvest it. Related, several participants with smaller amounts of income from the accounts were not aware of how much income they were receiving from the account(s) and did not report withdrawing that income.

“I don’t know if I would call it income. I just put it back into my investments. I don’t take the money out and use it, I just maintain it. I consider it income when it comes to tax time, but when I think of income, I think of income on money that use. I guess it is income because I have to pay taxes on it but is not like income that I am using to pay mortgage. I know some people trade as a job, but it is not one of my primary income sources.” (P507)

“I maybe get interest of one or two dollars.” (P599)

“I am not getting anything substantial.” (P420)

“The dividend on stocks is every 3 months. The I bond, I actually don’t know. I just put money in and don’t think about it. The one-time payment from my bank is just once a year for my savings, so every 12 months.” (P507)

When asked about how frequently accounts generated income, five participants said their accounts generated income quarterly, five said their accounts generate income monthly, two said their accounts generated income every 6 months, and one said their account generated income once a year.

All participants were then asked whether there are any response options in Q11 that were confusing to them or that they think other people may not understand. Nine participants confirmed that there were no categories that were confusing. Three participants noted that some people may not know what a money market fund is, two participants thought that the

term mutual funds may confuse people, and one participant (P28) was confused about the response option “Share of stock in corporations or mutual funds,” explaining that they just have regular stocks, which doesn’t seem to fit in this category.

“I am sounding like an old guy; I am not sure people know what an interest-earning checking account is. Money market, that’s a toss-up for who would know what it is. Certificates of deposits, I think would confuse a lot of people. Savings bonds I think is questionable in this day and age. Who does savings bonds?” (P180)

“Well, I think they wouldn’t understand because they’ve maybe never looked into it. But I am sure that way the way they would see it is as a way to earn extra money or saving money or investing money. So, I don’t think there is any room for confusion, it’s just a lack of knowledge because they don’t look into it.” (P420)

All participants were then asked if they could think of anything missing from the list of response options. Eleven participants could not think of anything missing from this item. Two participants said that Bitcoin is missing from the list, one participant said that retirement accounts like a 401k are missing from the list, one participant said that annuities and real estate are missing from the list, and one participant said that a high-yield checking account is missing from the list and was not sure where that should go in this list of response options.

“I would just add annuities rather than other savings or investments. I would add real estate maybe, real estate is a big investment thing.” (P372)

“No but the thought just came to mind of Bitcoins and whatever money you might earn with that. On the news they say, ‘wow Bitcoin made me so much money’, so did you really make money or not?” (P180)

Participants that selected the response option “shares of stock in corporations or mutual funds” in Q11 were asked Q12, shown below.

Q12) Did you or anyone in this household receive any capital gains from shares of stock, mutual funds, or other assets in 2022?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Five participants confirmed that they did receive capital gains from shares of stock, mutual funds, or other assets in 2022, and three participants did not receive capital gains. When asked to explain in their own words what this question is asking, four participants explained that this question is asking if you earned any income from stocks, mutual funds, or other

assets in 2022. One participant explained that they had heard of capital gains but could not define it, and another said they knew what the term “gains” meant but not “capital gains.”

“Capital gains means I earned money, so yes, I did in 2022. It’s asking did you earn capital gains from stock, mutual funds, or other things in 2022.”

(P372)

Recommendations

If the intent of the response options “interest-earning checking account” or “Savings account” in Q11 is to assess accounts that generate income, we recommend clarifying these response options as seven participants who did not report interest on these accounts in Q1 reported having the accounts in Q11 but explained that they are basic checking or savings accounts that do not accrue any significant interest or generate income. Related, one participant was also uncertain what to select for their “high-yield checking” account and felt it was missing from the list.

Consider adding the phrase “even small amounts” in Q1 and Q11 to encourage participants to report interest accounts that generate small amounts of interest income.

Three participants noted that people may not know what a money market fund is and two thought that mutual funds may confuse people. An explanation of these accounts could be of assistance; however, only three participants thought these terms could be confusing.

Based on feedback from participants, consider adding Bitcoin, annuities, and real estate as response options in Q11.

3.2.6 Unemployment Compensation

Participants who reported receiving unemployment compensation in Q1 were first asked to explain more about the compensation they received. Of the 25 participants, two participants (P52, P505) reported this income in Q1. One participant (P52) receives unemployment benefits but was unsure whether it was from the federal or state government describing it as a “regular unemployment claim.” The other participant (P505) explained that they were working until November 2023 when they lost their job, and they have been receiving unemployment compensation since then.

All participants were then asked to respond to Q13, shown below.

Q13) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in the household receive any State or Federal unemployment compensation?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Four participants responded “Yes” to Q13. Of the two participants who reported this income in Q1, one (P52) responded “Yes” and the other (P505) responded “No.” After further probing, it was noted that P505 correctly responded to this question because they were receiving unemployment compensation in 2023 and 2024, not in 2022. Three participants (P220, P54, and P420) responded “Yes” to Q13 but did not report this as a source of income in Q1. Upon further probing all three of these participants correctly responded to Q13 as they received unemployment compensation during 2022, while Q1 asked about their current sources of income.

Participants who responded “Yes” to Q13 were then probed to gather information about the type of assistance they received, how they received it, how frequently they received it, and how much they received. Two participants confirmed that the unemployment compensation came from the state that they live in, and two participants were not sure whether the unemployment came from the state or federal government. Two participants explained that they received the compensation via a direct deposit into their checking account while one explained that the funds were deposited onto their Bank of America card. Three participants confirmed that they received unemployment compensation every 2 weeks, and one received it every week. One participant (P52) received \$780 every 2 weeks, one (P220) received \$400 every 2 weeks, and another (P420) received \$900 every 2 weeks. One participant indicated they no longer receive unemployment and did not indicate how they had previously received their payments or the amount but recalled they received it every week.

Participants who responded “No” to Q13 were then asked if they have ever applied for or received unemployment compensation in the past. Of the 22 participants who responded “No” to Q13, 12 confirmed that they have. Of these 12 participants, five explained that they received unemployment when they lost their jobs, two received unemployment compensation during the pandemic because of shutdowns, three explained that they received unemployment decades ago, and two applied for unemployment compensation in the past but were denied.

“I applied in 2020 when the pandemic hit, and everything shut down. I didn’t have a fulltime job then, I was just doing my business, and my locations were shut down where I had my machines, they were in businesses and bars and locations that were shut down, so I applied for unemployment.” (P28)

“During a work year I would get laid off for lack of work and then I would file for state unemployment compensation, and it would not be every year, the economy would dictate a good year or a bad year and if there was work or not.” (P211)

These participants were then probed about the type of assistance they received and who it was from, how they received it and how frequently they received it, and how much they received. Four participants received unemployment compensation from the state they lived

in, one participant said they received both pandemic unemployment from their state in addition to the money received from the federal government, one participant said they received unemployment compensation from the city they lived in, and one just said that they received “unemployment compensation.” Two participants received unemployment compensation via direct deposit and three participants received a check. When asked how frequently they received unemployment compensation two participants received it monthly, two received it every 2 weeks, and two received it weekly. Two participants could not remember how much they received, and one reported they received \$3,200 a month.

Participants were then asked what kind assistance they think Q13 is asking about. Most participants explained that this question is referring to unemployment compensation that comes from the state or federal government when a person is unemployed and looking for a new job.

“It says ‘state or federal unemployment compensation’ so I am assuming state or federal.” (P28)

“I am reading it as you work at a job, something happens, the company goes away, you are fired, and you are eligible by the standards of your state to receive unemployment.” (P180)

“I would interpret it the way it’s worded, as state unemployment. If there was ever federal unemployment, I never filed for it, I always filed for state. I was always paying taxes for the state, yes, I have federal income tax, but I would not receive federal unemployment compensation in the job I had.” (P211)

Recommendations

Currently, Q1 does not have a timeframe and the timeframe for Q13 is 2022. If the intent of Q1 is to assess sources of income in the current year and the intent of Q13 is to assess whether participants received unemployment compensation in the prior year, then this is working as intended. However, if the intent of Q1 and Q13 is to capture unemployment compensation received in the same year, a timeframe should be added to Q1. Three participants (P220, P54, and P420) did not report this income in Q1 but responded “Yes” to Q13 because they received unemployment compensation in 2022, and one (P505) reported unemployment compensation in Q1 but responded “No” to Q13 because they received this compensation in 2023 and 2024, not 2022.

3.3.7 Cognitive Testing of Other ASEC Questions

School Meals

At the beginning of this section, all participants were asked to respond to a screener question asking if there are any children between the ages of 5–18 in their household. Of

the 25 participants, nine reported having children in this age range in their household. These participants were then asked to respond to Q16 and Q17, shown below.

Of the nine participants who reported having children between the ages of 5-18 in their household, two participants reported their children did not eat breakfast or lunch provided by the school, two participants reported their children ate only lunch provided by the school, and five participants reported their children ate breakfast and lunch provided by the school. Of the seven participants whose children ate breakfast and/or lunch provided by the school, four participants' children received free/reduced-price school meals.

Q16) During 2022, did any children ages 5 to 18 in this household usually eat a breakfast, lunch, or both provided by the school? *If yes: Was that breakfast, lunch, or both?*

	Breakfast	Lunch	Did not eat meals offered by school
[Child 1 name]			

Q17) (IF NECESSARY): During 2022, did any of these children receive free or reduced-price school meals? *If yes: Was that breakfast, lunch, or both?*

	Breakfast	Lunch	Did not receive free/reduced-price school meals
[Child 1 name]			

When asked how easy or difficult it was to answer these questions most of the participants indicated that Q16 and Q17 were very straightforward and easy to answer. One participant (P506) noted that if Q17 is trying to assess a free/reduced-price program, then it needs to be more specific because children in their state can get free lunch although this is not based on income and not part of a program. This participant also noted that it is hard to answer this question without knowing why they are being asked or what Census Bureau will do with the information, noting that it feels very invasive.

When asked to explain more about the meals that children in the household ate, one participant (P55) explained that their son eats lunch provided by the school. This participant pays a set amount for the whole year for lunch, and their son eats the lunch at school on most days. They confirmed that breakfast is offered at the school, but their son does not eat breakfast at the school, and they would have to pay for it. One participant (P363) responded "Yes" to both Q16 and Q17, but it was later discovered upon later probing this participant was thinking back to when they were in middle school and high school and would eat lunch at school. This participant is now in college, so they were not thinking about 2022.

“Well, they always tell me that they are healthy meals. I will say that they both do say that they are still hungry but that they get healthy meals. They do eat breakfast and lunch.” (P399)

“He just pays for lunch at lunchtime, or sometimes he will take his own lunch depending on what he felt like.” (P420)

When asked how meals were paid for, three participants personally paid for the school meals that their children ate, three participants explained that the meals were paid for by the free/reduced-price food program for children, and one participant (P54) explained that the food assistance their child receives at school is based on the father’s income and the participant believes that he receives a subsidy for the amount he pays. The participants whose children did not eat free/reduced-price meals either knew of other children at the school who ate free/reduced-price meals or assumed that there were children at the school who ate free/reduced-price meals.

“Yes, sometimes he would run out of time, and he would ask me for money if he didn’t pack his own lunch.” (P420)

“I believe it’s either the school district or the free/reduced food program for children.” (P399)

Participants were then asked if their responses would be the same or different for the other children in their household. Two participants only had one child in the household. Three participants confirmed that their responses would be the same for the other children in the household. One participant (P363) noted that their answers would be different, explaining that one child sometimes eats breakfast at school but eats lunch at the school every day, whereas their other children usually ate breakfast at the school every day.

When looking at Q16 participants were asked what the term “usually” means to them. Participants explained that “usually” means that a majority of the time, or more often than not, the child eats meals provided by the school.

“I would say like mostly, every day, most frequently is what I would consider usually.” (P599)

“Usually means more often than not.” (P54)

“Majority of the time.” (P28)

When asked if participants answers to Q16 would change if the question asked if their children “ever” ate a breakfast, lunch, or both provided by the school instead of “usually,” three participants confirmed that their responses would not change, one participant said their response would change because then the question would then be asking essentially if there were a “couple of times” the child ate at school, and one participant said they would

need to see the wording of the question but that they liked the current wording of the question.

"Yes, then it would make me think there was a couple of times where the child at school both breakfast and lunch." (P420)

"Like one time in their entire life? I would have to see the question. The question the way it is worded currently makes sense to me." (P506)

Recommendations

Because participants understood the term "usually" to mean that a majority of the time, or more often than not, a child eats meals provided by the school, and three of five participants confirmed that their responses would not change if the question asked if their child "ever" at breakfast or lunch provided by the school, we suggest keeping the question wording as is.

WIC

All participants were asked Q18, shown below. Of the 25 participants, none of the participants in this round of interviews reported receiving WIC—the Women, Infants, and Children Nutrition Program—in 2022. Because none of the participants reported receiving WIC in 2022, the probe in the interviewer protocol asking who received WIC for themselves or on behalf of a child was not administered.

Q18) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive WIC – the Women, Infants, and Children Nutrition Program?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

When asked how easy or difficult it was to answer this question, 17 participants confirmed that this question was simple, straightforward, and easy to answer. One participant (P496) did not know what WIC was. One participant (P363) explained that this question was easy to answer because they knew their family received WIC when their brother was an infant, so they know they do not receive it anymore.

"I think it's extremely clear and concise so very simple, very easy." (P372)

"It was easy. It's either I do, or I don't, so it was easy for me to respond immediately." (P420)

"Fairly easy, it's a simple yes or no question." (P28)

"It was very easy to answer, there's no children." (P211)

In the interviewer protocol, any participants that reported receiving WIC would have been administered probes asking them to speak more about the benefits received from WIC in their household, including how the benefits were obtained or received and what types of benefits they were including in their answers to the question. However, because none of the participants reported receiving WIC in 2022, these probes were not administered.

Recommendations

Because most participants believed that this question was simple, straightforward, and easy to answer, we suggest keeping the question wording as is. However, we suggest including this question in further cognitive testing to assess understanding by participants that receive WIC.

SNAP

All participants were asked Q20 and Q21, shown below. Of the 25 participants, eight reported receiving benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program) in 2022. Five of these participants did not select the “Public assistance” option in Q1. However, unlike Q1–Q13, where participants were probed about discrepancies with Q1, the protocol for the “other ASEC questions” portion of the interview did not refer back to participants’ Q1 responses. As such, respondents were not probed about discrepancies with Q1 during Q20 probing. It is also noted that Q1 asked participants to report their current sources of income, whereas Q20 (SNAP question) asks participants to report about SNAP in 2022, which may be one potential source of these discrepancies. When responding to Q21, five participants reported receiving food assistance from a state program in 2022. These five participants also responded “Yes” to Q20. Three participants (P363, P46, P2) who reported receiving SNAP in Q20 responded “No” to Q21.

Q20) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program) or the Food Stamp program, or use a SNAP or food stamp benefit card? Do not include WIC benefits.

- Yes
- No

Q21) At any time during 2022, even for one month, did you or anyone in this household receive any food assistance from a state program? Do not include WIC benefits. Include SNAP (Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program).

- Yes
- No

Q22) (IF YES TO Q21): Who was covered by that food assistance during 2022?

Participants who responded “Yes” to Q21 were then asked Q22, which asks who was covered by the food assistance program in 2022. Four of the participants were thinking about themselves while one participant was thinking about themselves and their daughter. One participant (P8) explained that they rent a room in a group home, and they may consider other people in that home as part of their household. The participant explained they are not family and they do not know about each other’s finances or health plans, so they did not include them when responding to these questions and confirmed they were only thinking about themselves when responding.

All participants were asked how easy or difficult it was to respond to these questions. Of the participants who responded “No” to Q20 and Q21, a majority confirmed that the questions were easy to answer.

“I am familiar with SNAP and food assistance, so it wasn’t an issue for understanding what they were.” (P211)

“Easy, nothing with food or anything for us.” (P180)

“Since I don’t have the programs, it was easy for me to respond right away.” (P420)

For participants who responded “Yes” to either Q20 or Q21, two confirmed that the questions were easy to answer, but five experienced issues responding to these questions. After probing, it was noted that three of these participants should have responded “Yes” to Q21. Two of these participants did not think that SNAP was a state program, with one not reading the instructions to include SNAP benefits in their response. One of these participants received food stamps and answered “Yes” to Q20, but they did not know what SNAP was and that it included food stamps, so they responded “No” to Q21 because it did not include the term “food stamps.”

One participant (P46) responded “Yes” to 20, and “No” to 21 because they did not think that SNAP is a state program. They did not see the instruction to include SNAP. This participant should have responded “Yes” to Q21. Note that no additional participants reported missing this instruction, but participants were not directly probed to determine if they were reading instructions in italics.

One participant (P2) responded “Yes” to Q20 but “No” to Q21. This participant was confused about the term “state program” explaining that SNAP is federally funded, but the money is given to the state and the state reviews eligibility, issues the card, and provides the benefit amount. When responding to Q20 they were thinking about food stamps, they get an EBT card in Texas called the Lonestar card, so this participant should have responded “Yes” to Q21.

One participant (P211) was initially confused about Q21, explaining that they did not receive food assistance from the state. When they re-read the question, they saw that this question includes SNAP, which they receive, so they responded “Yes.”

One participant (P54) noted that the format of Q20 is confusing and not conducive to reading. This participant thought the question should say “receive SNAP benefits” or simply “receive SNAP” and remove “benefits from.” This participant responded “Yes” to Q20 and Q21.

One participant (P363) responded “Yes” to Q20 but “No” to Q21. This participant receives food stamps but did not know what SNAP was and that it includes food stamps. They responded “Yes” to Q20 because they receive food stamps but responded “No” to Q21 because it did not include the term food stamps. This participant should have responded “Yes” to Q21.

Participants who responded “Yes” to Q20 were then probed about the benefits received from SNAP, how the benefits were obtained or received, and what types of benefits they were including in their answers. Six participants confirmed that they receive SNAP, which is food assistance. Participants explained that they receive an amount monthly that is loaded onto a card to buy groceries and food. Four participants were thinking about SNAP, and one participant was thinking about SNAP and a food pantry. These participants were then asked if they have an EBT card as part of their benefits, and if they included the EBT card in their answer to these questions. All six confirmed that they have an EBT card.

Participants who responded “Yes” to Q20 or Q21 were asked if they included benefits from WIC in their answers to these questions. Three participants who responded “Yes” to Q20 or Q21 confirmed that they did not include WIC in their responses to these questions. Of these three, two confirmed that they do not receive WIC. For other participants who answered “Yes” to Q20 or Q21, this probe was skipped for time.

All participants were asked if they were aware of any nutritional assistance programs in their state that were not mentioned in these questions. Eleven participants were not aware of any other nutritional programs in their state. One participant (P496) noted that their insurance offers a food program, but they have never used it. Another participant (P52) explained that people can call “211,” which directs the caller to nearby soup kitchens and other resources. One participant (P220) also mentioned different food pantries from churches whereas one (P180) mentioned assistance for the elderly, explaining that they sometimes pick up magazines that have two to three pages of information about state agencies and private help.

Recommendations

Because of the confusion around Q21, which led three participants to respond “No” when they should have responded “Yes,” we suggest either adding text that reads “This includes

SNAP (Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program) and the Food Stamp program” in bold, not italic, to Q21 Alternatively, we suggest only asking Q20, as participants that responded “Yes” to this question were receiving SNAP, had EBT cards, and did not receive any other assistance from their state.

When asked about any other nutritional programs in their state, participants mentioned food programs through insurance or calling “211,” which directs the caller to soup kitchens and other resources, food pantries, and assistance for the elderly. Because some of these are not programs sponsored by the state, if Census Bureau would like to capture this assistance, they could include a question asking, “Did you receive any assistance from other food programs such as soup kitchens or food pantries?”

Energy Assistance

All participants were asked Q27, shown below. Of the 25 participants, three reported receiving energy assistance to help pay heating and cooling costs from the federal, state, or local government.

Q27) In 2022, did you receive energy assistance to help pay heating and cooling costs from the federal, state, or local government? *This assistance can be received directly by the household or it can be paid directly to the electric company, gas company, or fuel dealer.*

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

All participants were asked how easy or difficulty this question was to answer. A majority of the participants confirmed that this question is clear, straightforward, and easy to answer. One participant (P496) asked if this question includes solar panels, noting that you can get allowances for installing solar panels and that everyone can get these allowances, not only low-income individuals. This participant (P496) responded “No” to Q27.

When asked if there is anything about this question that is confusing to them or that they think other people might not understand, 13 confirmed that there is nothing about this question that is confusing to them or that they think other people might not understand.

“Easy. We pay every month for energy bills.” (P180)

“Very easy, all my bills are included in rent. I don’t qualify for that [energy assistance]. If I did qualify, I still wouldn’t because of my income from Social Security, there’s an income cap.” (P8)

“Oh, I think this question is very clear. You either get money to help pay your utility bills or you don’t.” (P372)

The participants who reported receiving energy assistance were then probed about the type of energy assistance they receive, how the energy assistance was obtained or received, and what types of energy assistance they were including in their answers to the question. One participant (P52) received assistance from a state program called Texas Utility Help, another (P1) received assistance from a program called PIPP, which pays a portion of the respondent's energy expenses, and one participant (P420) indicated that they applied for energy assistance when they were unemployed through the gas and electric company.

One participant (P52) who received assistance from a state program explained that assistance is applied for on a website. To qualify you must be in a certain income range. The program takes your income and reviews past bills and determines an amount to be paid directly to the light company and water utility. Another participant (P1) who received assistance from a program called PIPP explained that you apply for PIPP online. The program automatically deducts an amount from their bill so that the participant only has to pay a portion of it. One participant (P420) who received assistance through the gas and electric company explained that it was a reduction in their energy bill. Another participant (P52) was thinking about electricity and water while two (P1, P420) were thinking about their energy bills.

Participants who did not report receiving energy assistance were asked if they use anything other than their regular income to pay their heating and cooling costs. Eight participants did not use anything other than their regular income to pay their heating and cooling costs. One (P8) explained that their heating and cooling costs are part of their rent in their group home, and they pay their rent with Social Security money. Another (P2) mentioned that they asked their energy provider if they offer assistance for low-income customers, but they do not. This participant explained they pay bills from Social Security money or using virtual gift cards from focus groups and interviews. They indicated that they keep their energy expense to a minimum. One participant (P279) noted they pay their energy bills with their credit card, which is paid off with money from their job. One participant (P180) does not use anything other than their income to pay their energy bills, but they mentioned that they are on a budgeting plan with their energy company.

Recommendations

Participants that received energy assistance correctly responded to this question and were able to explain the energy assistance received. Participants who did not report receiving energy assistance believed this question was straightforward and easy to respond to. Because of this, we do not recommend any changes to this question.

Housing Assistance

All participants were asked to respond to Q28 and Q29, shown below.

Q28) Is this public housing, that is, is it owned by a local housing authority or other public agency?

- Yes
- No

Q29) Are you paying lower rent because the Federal, State, or local government is paying part of the cost?

- Yes
- No

None of the participants in this round of interviews reported living in public housing owned by a local housing authority or other public agency (Q28). One participant (P52) responded “Yes” to Q29 asking whether they are paying lower rent because the federal, state, or local government is paying part of the cost. This participant receives Section 8 through Dallas Housing Authority.

All participants were asked how easy or difficult it was to answer Q28 and Q29. Fourteen participants confirmed that these questions were very easy to answer. One participant (P28) indicated that they were not certain of their responses to these questions and that they felt these items were confusing and was not sure how they would know this information.

“I mean I was confused because the question just came out of nowhere asking about housing, I didn’t understand why it was there. It was kind of random and I didn’t know how to answer because I was like ‘how would I know this?’” (P28)

Three participants indicated that they were confused by either Q28 or Q29, specifically by the term “public housing.” One participant (P399) did not know what public housing was. Another (P507) noted that the way the questions is worded implies that they live in public housing, and one (P599) was not sure why they needed to reply to Q29 as they responded “No” to Q28, which asks about public housing.

“I don’t know how you could be confused. If you don’t know that you live in public housing you got issues besides not being able to fill out this survey, and the same with the rent, either you know you get rent subsidized or you know you don’t get rent subsidized.” (P372)

“Very easy, I don’t live in public housing, I live on a ranch.” (P8)

“Easy. For Q28, it’s a private house and we are not renting anything for Q29.” (P180)

“Q28 was a bit difficult. I don’t really get it. That is why I went back.” [It is noted that the participant went back to the previous question to try to

understand, thinking they had responded “yes” to something to get this question because it says, “is this public housing.”] (P599)

“Q28 I am not going to lie was a little confusing. Q29 I am definitely certain.” [And why would you say Q28 is confusing?]: “Because it’s asking if it’s public housing or owned by a local housing authority or other public agency. I answered no, maybe it’s the way it’s worded. I am guessing that housing authority is the state? I have no idea to be honest.” (P399)

When asked if there is anything about these questions that was confusing to them or that that they think others may not understand, 10 participants confirmed that there was nothing confusing to them. However, some participants were confused by these items. One participant (P151) believes that there should be a “not applicable” response option for Q28. Another participant explained that when Q28 asks “is this” some people may not know what “this” is and that it should ask if the person resides in public housing. One participant (P402) reported that they were confused because the question implies that they live in public housing. Another (P28) was confused because these questions seem different than the other questions in the survey. The last (P2) was not familiar with these programs. They explained that there may be a housing assistance program in their city, but it has to be housing in certain areas. They noted that housing is a little cheaper for them because they live in an older building. Their county did have some rent assistance, but they checked about this a year ago and the money is gone.

“Well, it did kind of confuse me [Q28] because I thought ‘wait I don’t get any public housing, so it almost kind of assumes that you do receive public housing, at least that’s how I took it when I first read it. For Q29, that wasn’t confusing, so I just said no.” (P420)

“I mean I was confused because the question just came out of nowhere asking about housing, I didn’t understand why it was there. It was kind of random and I didn’t know how to answer because I was like ‘how would I know this?’” (P28)

When asked what “public housing” means to participants in Q28, seven participants considered “public housing” to be Section 8 housing. Eight participants explained that “public housing” is subsidized housing paid for by the government and that the government either pays for or pays for part of the rent based on a person’s income and family size.

“Well, you know I have been aware of public housing since I was 5 years old. They were called projects a lot when I was growing up. There’s one a few miles away from where I live. And it’s housing that the government owns and it’s for low-income folks and they pay a much lower rent to live there than they would pay in private housing.” (P372)

"Public housing to me is subsidized housing. The government will assist in paying your rent." (P211)

"Public housing is Section 8. The government pays either the full rent or a portion of rent in Section 8, based off of the recipient's income and family size." (P1)

"My taxes going to the government to pay for other people's places of residence to help them out." (P180)

When asked what "Section 8" means to participants, six participants thought that Section 8 is the same as public housing, three participants did not know what Section 8 is, and three participants explained that with Section 8 individuals can choose where they want to live and the government pays for all or part of the rent.

"Well, they say public housing assistance is different than Section 8, like they are both housing but it's different forms of it. Like Section 8 is where you get assistance, you can find your own home and get assistance with paying, but then public housing is housing and developments that are built, and you have to pick the area you want to live in." (P399)

"I really don't know, I've heard the term, but I don't know. My guess is that you have to meet a minimum of income to get Section 8." (P211)

"It's a program where people can live wherever they want but the government pays 80% and you pay 30%, something like that." (P8)

"It has to do with housing. I think it is a program to assist low-income families or the disabled." (P599)

Recommendations

A couple of participants noted that the way that Q28 is worded implies that the participant lives in public housing, which led to confusion, and one participant noted that the phrase "is this" in the question could cause confusion because participants may not know what "this" is. We recommend looking for other ways to word the question. For example, asking "do you live in public housing, that is, is it owned by...."

Many participants did not know what public housing or Section 8 is. Providing examples of this type of housing may help participants understand the question.

Several participants reported that Section 8 and public housing are the same thing. If the Census Bureau is trying to determine participants that live in Section 8 housing vs. public housing it is suggested that public housing and Section 8 are asked about separately. If they are trying to determine participants who live in public housing or Section 8 housing it is suggested that Section 8 be added to Q28.

Medical Expenses

All participants were asked to respond to Q23–Q26, which ask about insurance premiums, co-pays and medical care, and out-of-pocket costs. Several participants had trouble responding to one or more of the questions in this set. Some were uncertain about what questions were asking about, what should be included, or what the differences were between some of the questions, and many noted they were not certain about their answers or provided “guesses” in their responses. These issues are discussed in more detail for each question in the following section.

Premiums. All participants were first asked to respond to Q23, as shown below.

Q23) Last year, how much did you pay out-of-pocket for ALL health insurance premiums covering yourself or others in the household? *Include both comprehensive and supplemental plans (such as vision and dental insurance). Do NOT include Medicare deductions from any Social Security or Social Security Disability payments mentioned earlier.*

[Dollar field]

Participants provided a range of responses to Q23. Ten participants entered “\$0” for this question and indicated they either did not have insurance or were on Medicare or Medicaid and did not have to pay a premium. Fourteen participants provided an answer, with one respondent (P278) indicating they have premiums but were not sure of an amount and were not able to provide a response. Dollar amounts provided had a range of \$200 to \$33,000, an average of \$4,789, and a median of \$2,000. The participant (P496) who reported \$33,000 indicated they had a health savings account, which was the figure they were reporting.

When asked how easy or difficult it was to answer this question, 13 participants reported some difficulty responding. Five participants noted it was difficult because they did not have the information or would need to consult others in the household to provide more accurate responses.

“This was quite difficult. I had to give a rough estimate. I would have to calculate to give an answer.” (P599)

“It was challenging to answer because I had to think about how much I paid each month.” (P220)

“I don’t keep track. Most of that is taken out already.” (P278)

There was also some confusion observed with the term “out-of-pocket” used in this question, which resulted in some participants including other “out-of-pocket” expenses. Six participants considered other “out-of-pocket” expenses, such as what they paid at the

doctor for co-pays or what they paid after insurance covered their portion of the cost. One participant (P363) entered the amount paid out-of-pocket braces last year. Four participants (P151, P55, P211, P506) were uncertain if they should include co-pays they paid at the doctor in their response. Another participant (P507) said the term “out-of-pocket” was confusing because insurance premiums come out of a person’s paycheck before it is dispersed, and they don’t think about premiums as “out-of-pocket” expenses.

“This is a confusing question because the [term] ‘pay out-of-pocket’ for all healthcare insurance premiums.’ So, it’s asking me about how much I paid for insurance. It’s also asking me how much I paid out-of-pocket after insurance covered paying for something. I still paid out-of-pocket after insurance paid for a procedure and the doctor didn’t get all of his money.” (P211)

“[I] would have to try and remember all doctor visits and how much they cost. No way.” (P506)

“Does this include monthly payment and what you pay when seeing the doctor?” (P55)

“These expenses were low because no one in the household was very sick or needed to go to the hospital last year.” (P138)

Related, one participant provided their plan’s yearly deductible amount, not their premium, because they met their deductible and that is what they paid “out-of-pocket.”

“It is a tough question. I think my deductible on my plan was \$2,500, so if you’re comfortable with that response that is what I’d go with.” (P90)

Two participants (P279, P220) were initially unsure if they should include the monthly payment amount or the amount for the entire year. One of these participants (P279) decided to calculate the total by multiplying monthly payments, and one participant (P220) provided the amount that was deducted from their social security each month for their insurance.

When asked how certain they were of their responses, eight reported not being certain about the figures they provided, with five reporting they estimated or “guessed.”

“It is kind of a wild estimate actually.” (P180).

“It’s a total guess. Could be totally wrong – not even close.” (P506)

“I don’t know the answer to that because it’s taken out [of my paycheck] already.” (P278)

Finally, participants were asked what the term “premium” meant to them. Although there was some confusion about what costs to include in Q23, 16 participants generally described premiums correctly (e.g., amount paid to maintain insurance coverage).

“Premium is what you pay every month to have insurance.” (P48)

“A monthly rate that someone pays for insurance.” (P52)

“Premium is the price of your insurance.” (P211)

“What you pay to an insurance company to cover you for your benefits.” (P180)

However, others provided descriptions that did not align with the meaning of “premium” as it is intended in this question and instead described deductibles or something that insurance pays.

“It is a little bit of a tougher word for most people. Premiums can be something in addition to, or a bonus. When I think of premiums I think of a bonus or incentive offer through insurance.” (P54)

“What does your insurance costs to meet your deductible.” (P90)

“[That] insurance covers some of the cost” (P363)

Co-pays and Medical Care. Participants were then asked to respond to Q24, which asks about “out-of-pocket” expenses for their own medical care.

Q24) Last year, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your OWN medical care, such as copays for doctor and dentist visits, diagnostic tests, prescription medicine, glasses and contacts, and medical supplies? Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone else in this household.

[Dollar field]

Four participants provided “\$0” responses. One participant (P278) noted they would not know how to answer this question and did not provide a response. Twenty participants provided responses with a range of \$20 to \$7,000, an average of \$1,691, and a median of \$500. The participant (P399) that reported only \$20 provided their co-pay amount.

When asked how easy or difficult Q24 was, seven participants reported having some difficulty or were uncertain about how to respond. Two participants also reported providing “guesses.”

“Oh my god! I'm sorry, but this would be my real-life reaction. I have no idea.” (P220)

“Again, a wild estimate. I don’t have that many medical bills.” (P180)

Two participants (P48, P211) noted it was difficult to think about expenses for co-pays in addition to all the other costs for other medical expenses (e.g., tests). Related, one participant (P507) was uncertain if they should include over the counter medication under “medical supplies.”

“There’s too many things in there, like the prescriptions, the glasses, the diagnostic tests, the dental, etc. to group it all together. You’re going to get more of an estimate than a proper number. My eyecare covers up to \$2,000, anything out-of-pocket I wouldn’t know. Separate them into not such a broad group.” (P211)

“Easy to put the number, but difficult to think about all copays plus tests, visits...”. (P48)

“When I hear medical supplies, I also think of first aid stuff and over the counter medication I use to help my skin condition, but I am not including these things in this number.” (P507)

When asked about the difference between Q23 and Q24, seven participants had trouble discerning the difference between the two items, and what information each was requesting, and three participants felt they were asking similar things.

“I really don’t see a difference, because they are both asking out of pocket expenses for medical care.” (P90)

“There doesn’t seem to be a whole lot of difference to me.” (P180)

One participant (P278) described Q23 as what is paid by health insurance, and Q24 as what is paid by an individual/household. Two participants felt the only difference between Q23 and Q24 was that Q24 asked just about the participant’s own expenses, whereas Q23 asked about the entire household.

“[In Q23] if you have family, include what you pay for everyone. [In Q24] Include just your own. That’s the only difference.” (P279).

“Well in 23 you are asking for everybody in the household and in 24 you are just asking about me.” (P28)

Out-of-pocket costs. Participants were then asked to respond to Q25–Q26 and report their out-of-pocket costs for non-prescription healthcare products (Q25) and their total out-of-pocket costs for medical care (Q26).

Q25) Last year, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your non-prescription healthcare products such as vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, pain relievers, quit smoking aids, and anything else not yet reported? *Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.*

[Dollar field]

Q26) Last year, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your OWN medical care (e.g., copays for doctor and dentist visits, diagnostic tests, prescription medicine, glasses and contacts, and medical supplies) AND non-prescription healthcare products (e.g., vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, pain relievers, quit smoking aids, and other expenses)? *Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.*

[Dollar field]

For Q25, four participants provided \$0 responses. Twenty participants provided responses with a range of \$20 to \$2,000, an average of \$360, and a median of \$200. For Q26, six participants provided \$0 responses. One of these participants (P28) noted in subsequent probing this figure was actually \$700–\$1000. Eighteen provided responses with a range of \$50–\$10,000, an average of \$2,225, and a median of \$2,200. One participant (P278) noted they would not know how to answer either of these questions about out-of-pocket costs.

Participants were then asked how easy or difficult it was to respond to Q25 and Q26 and how certain they were about their responses. Eleven participants reported some difficulty with questions, and 12 reported providing estimates. One participant (P52) who is not insured felt the term “out-of-pocket” made them think the questions were only for those who are insured. Another (P55) noted the questions were long, and they had to read the items “2 or 3 times” before responding. Five participants noted it was difficult because they did not have the information available in the moment or noted they would need to consult others in the household. One participant (P151) suggested using the term “over the counter” instead of “non-prescription” would help some participants better understand what these questions were asking about. Three participants felt the two questions sounded alike, or were asking for similar data, which caused some confusion.

Participants were then probed about the differences between Q25 and Q26. Although some understood that Q26 was asking them to report totals from both Q24 and Q25, six had difficulty discerning the difference between these items and felt they were the same.

“This is the one (Q25) I had to go back to..., so I guess it was a little confusing. It felt like I was answering the same question twice but looking at them next to each other I see that one was the total amount, and one was just myself.” (P420)

"One is about medicine over the counter, and the other is about over the counter stuff too." (P8)

"It is getting confusing to me because it [Q26] doesn't seem to me any different from the \$2,500 [reported in Q23 and Q24]. To me it seems redundant." (P90)

"They seem to run together." (P180)

"No, they are the same." (P211)

"Isn't Q26 the same as Q25?" (P506)

Four other participants focused on the differences between the medication/healthcare products listed in each item, not mentioning the other medical care expenses (e.g., co-pays, doctor visits, tests) asked about in Q26.

"One [Q26] is referring to nonprescription and prescription. Q25 is only asking about nonprescription expense (P52)

"Q25 is asking about expenses for prescriptions only while Q26 asks about non-prescription items." (P138)

"Q25 is over counter. Q26 is prescription doctor gives you" (279)

"Well 25 says non-prescription and 26 says prescription and non-prescription." (P28)

Five participants recognized that Q26 was asking them to report values from Q24 and Q25. However, three participants (P496, P507, P372) were confused why Q26 was asking them to provide data they felt they had already included in Q24 and Q25.

"I think it would be these two amounts (Q24 and Q25) added. This is confusing. It is awkward because I already did this, and doing math off the top of your head can throw people off. If I am understanding this is asking about Q24 and then the last question (Q25) and I think it is the combination, but it almost looks like a math problem. I would assume it would do the math for me." (P507)

"Well, Q26 is basically a combination of Q25 and Q24, and it seems redundant. I already broke down Q24 for you, I already broke down my premiums for you, I already broke down my out-of-pocket for copays and prescriptions, and I already broke down my out-of-pocket for OTCs, so why do I need to do that again?" (P372)

Related, some participants reported that it would be generally burdensome to calculate these figures.

"I understand what each of these things are, I just would have to go look up doctor bills and credit card bills, and I don't even know if I have those things. Logistically, not very convenient for whoever is taking this." (P506)

Recommendations

The use of the term "out-of-pocket" expenses appeared to result in misreporting for Q23. Several participants focused on the term "out-of-pocket" and reported expenses that are more commonly associated with "out-of-pocket" medical costs, like co-pays, deductibles, and other expenses that insurance does not cover and must be paid by the recipients of care. A few were also confused because premiums for employer-based plans are typically taken out of pay before it is dispersed, so they did not equate premium payments as coming "out-of-pocket" in a traditional sense. We suggest avoiding this term as it relates to premiums and instead providing a definition of "premium" and instructions on what should be included. This would also help address the confusion with the term "premium" that was reported by some participants.

Several participants also had trouble differentiating between questions in this set and generally reported high levels of burden when responding. We recommend simplifying these questions to the extent possible and avoid asking respondents to sum across questions where data have already been provided as in the case of Q26. Instead, Census Bureau may consider computing these totals for the respondent and asking them to confirm the amounts.

Childcare Expenses

Participants were asked to answer ASEC questions related to childcare care expenses (Q30–Q32).

Q30) Now we want to ask about some of your expenses for children. Did you or anyone in this household PAY for the care of any children while you or they worked, searched for work or were in training/education in 2022?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Q31) Do you or does anyone in this household currently use any of the following types of child care for [CHILD]? Select all that apply.

- ☐ Pre-kindergarten or 3-K
- ☐ Head Start
- ☐ Preschool, nursery school, or daycare center
- ☐ Family daycare or paid care provided in someone else's home
- ☐ A paid babysitter or nanny in the home
- ☐ Free care with a relative

- Paid care with a relative
- Any other type of child care, specify: _____

Q32) Do you or does anyone in this household receive government assistance, for instance a voucher or child care subsidy, to help pay for [CHILD]’s child care?

- Yes
- No

Twenty-three participants reported not paying for childcare expenses in Q30, with only two participants (P48, P599) responding “yes” to this item. The majority of participants (22) skipped Q31 without selecting any responses as the question did not apply to them and there were no appropriate options for them to select (e.g., “not applicable”). However, one participant (P28), selected the “Any other type of childcare, specify” option and entered “I do not have children” in the text box. Only two participants (P599, P363) endorsed items in Q31. One of these participants (P599) indicated they pay for childcare in Q30 selecting “A paid babysitter or nanny” and “Free care from a relative” and another participant responded “No” to Q30 but selected “Free care from a relative” in Q31. All respondents selected “No” to Q32 and had no issues responding.

When asked how easy or difficult it was to respond to this set of questions, the majority of participants reported the items were “easy” and had no difficulty answering.

“I thought that they were extremely clear and concise, there shouldn’t be any issues answering them.” (P372)

However, note that this series of items was administered to all participants, regardless of whether they had indicated having children. As a result, several participants who reported not having children were confused when they received these questions. In particular, some participants were uncertain about how to respond to Q31 given there were no applicable response options for them to select.

“Again, this one (Q31) is not relevant to me, but there is no “not applicable.” I would just skip the question or I would click “any other” and specify that I don’t have children.” (P507)

Given these items will only be administered to households with children once in the field, this issue should not be a problem.

Appendix A: Recruitment Materials

A-1: Inbound Phone Calls and Participant Screening

If callers do not mention or inquire anything about participating in a research study:

- Confirm if callers are responding to one of the recruitment advertisements and interested in participating in our study.
- Conclude the call if they are not calling to participate.

If they already mentioned the study with the information from the recruitment advertisement:

Cover the following in the call:

- RTI international, a not-for-profit research organization, is conducting research on behalf of the Census Bureau
- We are conducting this research to improve the survey questions for the Current Population Survey
- We will ask you a few questions about your background and your household to determine if you are eligible for the interview.
- The screening questions will take about 10 minutes
- Eligible participants can receive \$40 for completing a virtual-person interview. Interviews will last about 1 hour.
- Confirm if callers want to proceed to be screened.

If they agree:

- Load up the web screener:
https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6W5afMdmLNqAgVE
- Read the questions from the web screener to the caller, adjusting the wording as necessary so that it makes sense as a phone survey that you are administering to the respondent.
- Enter their answers to the web screener on their behalf.
- Thank and end the call once you completed the survey for the caller. Let the respondent know that you will contact them again if they are eligible to participate in the study.
- Notify task lead that you have conducted a screener case by phone because we need to mark it in the tracker. REMINDER: Do not include any PII in messages or emails.

If they disagree:

- Politely end the call.

A-2: Initial Outreach Email

Subject line: Invitation to participate a Census Bureau Interview

Good [Morning/afternoon], FIRST NAME,

My name is RECRUITER NAME. I am contacting you because you recently expressed interest in participating in an interview to discuss your thoughts and opinions on questions asking about you and your household. This interview is being conducted by RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS) for the United States Census Bureau.

Your responses indicate that you are in **[TIME ZONE]**. Below are some available appointments for an interview:

- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**
- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**
- **DAY/TIME (INCLUDING RESPONDENT TIME ZONE)**

The interview should take about an hour, and you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card as a thank you for participating in the interview.

Please let me know what time works best for you. Once we confirm the appointment time, I will send an invitation email for the interview.

Thank you,

RECRUITER NAME

A-3: Interview Calendar Invitation Template

Event title: [CPS/ASEC] Census Bureau Interview

This calendar invite is for your Census Bureau interview. Thank you again for agreeing to participate!

As a reminder:

- Your interview is scheduled for **[DAY], [DATE], from [START TIME] to [END TIME]**.
- The interview will be conducted virtually using the video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The link and information for joining the meeting is below. Please click on the link to connect with your interviewer at your scheduled meeting time.**
- You will receive a \$40 electronic gift card as a thank you for your participation in the interview.
- The interviewer's name is **[INTERVIEWER NAME]**.

Before the interview, please review the consent information linked here:

[ASEC: https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_0VvVyo6zWUe9Xo2]

[CPS: https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_7V9w8f5XKOEWRgO]

Your interviewer will review it when you meet, and you can ask any questions you may have.

If you need to reach us before the interview, please reply to this email.

If you need to reach us on the day of your interview, please call me at **866-280-1520**.

Thank you for your participation!

RECRUITER NAME

A-4: Recruitment Advertisement

Get paid for sharing your opinions

RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The interview will take about 60 minutes. We will provide \$40 for participating in the remote interview.**

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6W5afMdmLNqAgVE

You may also call 866-280-1520 to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

A-5: Reminder Email Template

Schedule send to go out the day of the interview

Subject line: Census Bureau Interview Reminder – DATE at TIME

(RECRUITER: Be sure to CC the interviewer’s Census email in this email)

Good [Morning/afternoon], FIRST NAME,

This is a reminder about your interview on **DATE at TIME (time zone)**. Thank you again for agreeing to participate! Below are the details about the appointment. I have also sent you a calendar invite to help reserve the time on your schedule.

Some important notes:

- The interview will be conducted using Microsoft Teams and the link is listed here for your reference. Please click on this link to connect with the interviewer at your scheduled time.
 - [link]
 - I have attached instructions for how to use Teams when joining from a computer or mobile device.
- [ONLY INCLUDE THIS BULLET IF RESPONENT IS CALL IN ONLY] The phone number to dial in is 347-973-4395. Use the meeting ID XXXXXXXX to join
- Before the interview, please review the consent information linked here:

[ASEC: https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_0VvVyo6zWUe9Xo2]

[CPS: https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_7V9w8f5XKOEWRgO]

Your interviewer will review it when you meet and you can ask any questions you may have.

Please respond to this email or give me a call if you have any questions or need to reschedule your interview.

Sincerely,
RECRUITER NAME
866-280-1520

Appendix B: ASEC Health Insurance Exploratory Interviews Protocol

PARTICIPANT ID #: _____ DATE: ____ / ____ / ____

INTERVIEWER'S NAME: _____

START TIME: ____: ____ AM / PM END TIME: ____: ____ AM/PM

1) Protocol Introduction

[READ OR PARAPHRASE]

Hello, I'm [NAME] with [CONTRACTOR], a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. Thanks for agreeing to help us today. Let me tell you a little about what we will be doing.

We are conducting a study so we can learn how to best ask questions on topics like health insurance in Census Bureau surveys. Since people receive health insurance in different ways, it is important to write questions that make sense to everyone and are easy to answer. It is important that everyone understands the questions in the same way because people's answers to the questions help us produce statistics about the U.S. This survey asks questions about you and other people who live with you.

If you agree to take part in this study, I will ask you some questions to learn more about you and your household. Sometimes I will ask you a follow up question that may sound a little strange. For example, I might ask you what a certain word or question means to you or how you came up with your answer. The reason for this is to learn about the process you go through in your mind when you answer the questions. There are no right or wrong answers. We are interviewing people from all over the country to help find the words and questions that will work best for everyone.

Your participation in this interview is very important because it will help the Census Bureau improve its surveys. You will receive \$40. [CONTRACTOR WILL DESCRIBE HOW RESPONDENT WILL RECEIVE INCENTIVE]

2) Informed consent

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review and sign this form? [IF NO, PASTE LINK INTO CHAT or email if chat not working: Can you please open the link to this form I shared in the chat?]

[CONSENT LINK]

I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to audio and video-record our conversation, including a screen recording of you and your responses to the web survey that we will review together.

This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.

- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 1 hour.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.

[IF OBSERVER IS PRESENT: I also wanted to let you know that this interview is being observed by someone from the Census Bureau/someone else who works on this study. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in learning how our surveys work, and whether we need to change something that does not work.]

Do you have any questions about this information? [IF YES: ADDRESS PARTICIPANT QUESTIONS].

Do you agree to participate in this interview? [IF YES: CONTINUE WITH INTERVIEW. IF NO: ADDRESS ANY PARTICIPANT CONCERNS. IF STILL UNWILLING TO PARTICIPATE, TERMINATE INTERVIEW].

Is it okay if I record this interview today? [IF YES: START RECORDING AND COLLECT VERBAL CONSENT ON RECORDING. IF NO: CONTINUE WITH INTERVIEW WITHOUT RECORDING.]

Now that recording has started, can you confirm that you agree to participate in this interview and be recorded?

[IF PARTICIPANT HAS NOT ALREADY SIGNED FORM]: Please go ahead and sign and date both sections of the form and click "Submit."

INTERVIEWER:

1. DID THE PARTICIPANT HAVE ANY QUESTIONS OR CONCERNS?

- Yes
- No (SKIP TO QUESTION 3)

2. PLEASE SPECIFY:

3. HAS THE PARTICIPANT READ AND SIGNED THE INFORMED CONSENT?

- Yes
- No (END INTERVIEW)

3) Interview Part 1. Exploring Coverage and General Knowledge about Health Insurance

4) Section 1: Medical care and coverage

1.1. To start, can you tell me about where you usually go when you want to see a doctor or other medical professional? USE FOLLOWING PROBES AS NEEDED:

1.1a. Where do you go if you need a vaccine or a check-up?

1.1b. Where do you go if you are sick or injured? (For example, a clinic, hospital, private doctor's office, or a medical professional?)

1.1c. IF PERSON SAYS THEY DON'T GO TO DOCTOR: When was the last time you saw a medical professional? Can you tell me about where you went? [IF PERSON SAYS NEVER GONE TO DOCTOR: SKIP TO QUESTION 3].

1.2. How do you pay for healthcare when you are sick? Was there a charge the last time you saw a doctor? Did you pay?

1.3. In your own words, what does a "health coverage" mean?

1.3a. What about "health plan"? "Health insurance"?

1.3b. Which of these terms do you hear used most often?

1.3c. Do they mean the same thing to you, or are they different?

1.4. TAILOR AS NEEDED: Could you tell me about any sort of health coverage you have for medical care? If nothing comes to mind, that is okay too.

1.4a. IF NEEDED: Do you know the name of this coverage?

1.4b. Do you have any other kind of coverage? Tell me more about that.

1.4c. What other types of health coverage have you heard of?

1.4d. [INTERVIEWER: NOTE IF R STRUGGLES TO DEFINE/DEFINES INCORRECTLY. IF NECESSARY, REPEAT EARLIER PROBES USING ALTERNATE TERMS LIKE "HEALTH INSURANCE"]

5) Section 2: Detailed coverage and knowledge assessment

PROBE RESPONDENT ON CURRENT COVERAGE. IF MORE THAN ONE TYPE OF CURRENT COVERAGE, ASK ABOUT ALL TYPES. IF NONE, OR IF INTERVIEW IS RUNNING SHORT, ASK PROBES ABOUT 1) MOST RECENT PREVIOUS TYPE OF COVERAGE, 2) OTHER HOUSEHOLD MEMBERS' COVERAGE.

6) If person has coverage:

2.1. How long have you had this coverage? PROBE TO SEE IF RESPONDENT CAN PROVIDE INFORMATION ON A MONTH AND YEAR.

2.1a Have there been any months since you first got this coverage that you were not covered by it?

IF COVERED FOR LESS THAN 2 YEARS:

2.1b. Did you have any kind of coverage before your current coverage? Tell me more about that. When did your coverage with that plan start and when did it end? PROBE TO SEE IF RESPONDENT CAN PROVIDE INFORMATION ON A MONTH AND YEAR.

2.1c. IF NEEDED: Were there any months between your current coverage and the one you had before it where you did not have any coverage—for example, if you were in between jobs?

2.2. How did you get your current coverage? What, if anything, did you have to do to sign up for it?

2.2a. IF R MENTIONS SOMETHING IMPLYING MARKETPLACE: Did you sign up for this coverage online?

2.2ai. IF YES: Would you be able to show me the website where you signed up?

2.2b. If someone else got this coverage for you, who was that and do you know how they signed up?

2.2c. IF R SAYS “I DON’T KNOW”: Can you say more about that? How do you know you are covered?

2.3. Thinking about your current health plan, what type of health care is covered? PROBE TO SEE

IF RESPONDENT IS INCLUDING SINGLE COVERAGE PLANS, SUCH AS DENTAL, DRUG, OR VISION PLANS.

2.4. Do you know if you have a premium, subsidy, or copays in your current coverage?

2.4a. Do you know what these amounts are?

2.4b. Do you know how your premium is paid?

2.4c. IF NEEDED AND COVERAGE THROUGH EMPLOYER: Is your premium deducted from your paycheck?

2.5. Who is the policyholder for your plan? NOTE IF R IS NOT SURE OF ANSWER.

2.5a. If not already apparent: Did you get that coverage through yourself or through someone else?

2.5b. If someone else: Who do you get your coverage through?

7) If person does not have coverage:

2.6. Have you EVER had health coverage or health insurance?

IF R SAYS NEVER: GO TO “ALL PEOPLE”

2.7. How did you get that health coverage? What, if anything, did you have to do to sign up for it?

2.7a. IF R MENTIONS SOMETHING IMPLYING MARKETPLACE: Did you sign up for this coverage online?

2.7ai. IF YES: Would you be able to show me the website where you signed up?

2.8. Thinking more about that last time you had health coverage. PROBE TO SEE IF RESPONDENT CAN PROVIDE INFORMATION ON A MONTH AND YEAR.

2.8a. How long did you have it?

2.8b. Did you have any kind of coverage before that one? Tell me more about that.

8) All People:

2.9. What kind of health coverage do other people in your household have? (If R says “None” skip to #2)

- 2.9a. IF DIFFERENT FROM R'S: Tell me more about that. How knowledgeable do you feel about their health coverage?
- 2.9b. IF THE SAME AS R'S: Does the other person in the household share your plan, or do they have their own?
- 2.9c. IF SAME AS R'S: Does anyone have something else in addition to this coverage?
- 2.9d. Is there anyone outside of the household who shares coverage with you or other people in the household? PROBE ABOUT SHARED CUSTODY IF NEEDED.
- 2.10. Now I'm going to ask about some terms used when talking about health coverage. This is not meant to be a test. We are just trying to understand the best ways to write questions about this topic.
- 2.10a. In your own words, what does a "premium" mean?
- 2.10b. What about "subsidy"?
- 2.10bi. Do you know what a subsidy is?
- 2.10bii. Can you describe in your own words how a subsidy works?
- 2.10c. What about a "co-pay"?
- 2.10d. What about a "policyholder"?
- 2.11. What other types of health plans or coverage have you heard of before, even if you do not have them?
- 2.11a. What are some other ways people can get healthcare?
- 2.12. ONLY IF TIME ALLOWS AND IF NOT APPARENT: Do you currently have a job or do you work for pay?
- 2.12a. If needed: Is health coverage available to you through your job?
- 2.12ai. If yes: Do you use this coverage? If yes and if needed: Is this the same coverage you already reported?
- 2.12aii. *If yes but R does not use: Can you tell me more about why you do not have coverage through your job? Tell me more about that.
- 2.12aiii. If no: Is health coverage available to anyone else at your job? If yes: Can you tell me more about who is offered coverage and who is not?
- 2.12b IF R IS MARRIED: Is health coverage available through your spouse's job? Do they use it? Tell me more about that.

9) Section 3. Alternative methods of collection

It is important for the Census Bureau to collect data on health insurance coverage because local and federal agencies use this data to plan government programs. However, health coverage can be complicated, and sometimes people are not totally sure what their health coverage is called or what type it is. Because of this, we often need to ask a lot of questions to make sure we understand what kind of coverage someone has.

- 3.1. For these questions, it will be helpful to reference your health insurance card if you have one. Please get out your health insurance card now if it's available to you.

[PAUSE TO ALLOW RESPONDENT TO GET HEALTH INSURANCE CARD]

[INTERVIEWER: ASK TO SEE CARD. RECORD BASIC INFORMATION AVAILABLE FROM THE CARD, SUCH AS NAME OF INSURANCE PROVIDER, NAME OF PLAN, TYPE OF PLAN (E.G., PPO, MEDICAID), AND

ANY INFORMATION FROM THE CARD ABOUT SERVICES COVERED. ASK ADDITIONAL PROBES BELOW AS NEEDED:]

- 3.1a. What is the name of the insurance or coverage provider listed on your card?
- 3.1b. What is the name of the plan?
- 3.1c. What type of plan is it [IF NEEDED: For example, is it an HMO, HSA, PPO, Medicaid]?
- 3.1d. What type of health care is covered by this plan?

3.2. I'd like you to imagine you are responding to a Census Bureau survey at home on your own. Which of the following would you prefer?

- 3.2a. Answering a list of questions designed to learn the type of plan you have
- 3.2b. the option to input basic information from your card, such as the name of your provider and your ID number, instead of answering the list of questions? Tell me more about that.
- 3.2c. the option to upload a photo of your insurance card instead of answering the list of questions? Tell me more about that.

[INTERVIEWER: NOTE ANY SPONTANEOUS PRIVACY AND CONFIDENTIALITY OR SECURITY CONCERNS, AND PROBE FOR MORE INFORMATION.]

10) Interview Part 2. Test Question Set A

For the next part of the interview, I'm going to ask you to answer a few additional questions in a web survey. Then I will have a few follow-up questions to learn more about how you came up with your answers to these questions.

[INTERVIEWER: OPEN WEB SURVEY, ENTER RESPONDENT ID NUMBER, AND SHARE SCREEN. YOU WILL ENTER RESPONSES ON RESPONDENT'S BEHALF]

11) Section 4: Part 1 of Proposed Question Set A

Self-response

Q1) Do you NOW have any type of health plan or health coverage?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No (DONE WITH QUESTION SERIES)

Q2) How do you get the coverage you have now?

- ☐ Through your job
- ☐ Through a spouse/partner or parent's job
- ☐ Government or state
- ☐ Some other way

Q3) Are you covered by any of the following? Mark all that apply.

- ☐ Medicare (for 65+ and people with disabilities)
- ☐ Medicaid, State Medicaid, Medical Assistance, or CHIP
- ☐ State exchange plan or other state health plan

If Q2 = Through your job or through a spouse/partner or parent's job, go to Q4

If Q2 = Government or state, go to Q5

If Q2 = Some other way, go to Q6

Interviewer Probes about Question Set A, Part 1

(SHOW RESPONDENT Q1-Q3 IN WORD DOCUMENT)

4.1. Looking at Q2, how did you decide which coverage category you are in? How about for Q3?

4.2. In your own words, what are these questions asking?

4.3. What are some examples of what might be included in the "government or state" category?

Thank you. Could you please answer the following next? [HAVE R ANSWER PART 2, THEN PROBE]

12) Section 5: Part 2 of Proposed Question Set A

Self-response

Q4) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- ☐ Current job
- ☐ Former job (if retired)
- ☐ Union
- ☐ Spouse/partner or parent's job
- ☐ TRICARE or TRICARE for Life
- ☐ Other Military coverage (specify)
- ☐ COBRA

Q5) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- ☐ Medicare (Parts A+B; Part C)
- ☐ Medicare Advantage
- ☐ Medicaid or Medical assistance
- ☐ State Medicaid program
- ☐ Through a state exchange or marketplace
- ☐ Indian Health Service
- ☐ Children's Health Insurance Plan (CHIP)
- ☐ Veterans Administration Coverage (VA Care, CHAMPVA)
- ☐ Other Military coverage, specify: _____
- ☐ Another government plan, specify: _____

Q6) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- ☐ Purchased directly from an insurance company or on the exchange or a marketplace
- ☐ Union
- ☐ Group or association, other than a union
- ☐ School
- ☐ Some other way, specify: _____

Q7) (If Q6= Some other way) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- Health insurance exchange or a marketplace, like healthcare.gov
- Health insurance from a company online or through a broker
- Union
- Group or association, other than a union
- School
- Some other way, specify: _____

Q8) (If Q7= Some other way) How did you get the coverage you have now?

- Purchased directly
- Union
- Group or association, other than a union
- School

Q9) (If Q8= Purchased directly) Where did you directly purchase the coverage you have now?

- Health insurance company online or through a broker
- Health insurance exchange or a marketplace, like healthcare.gov
- Some other way, specify: _____

[INTERVIEWER: STOP SCREENSHARE AND ADMINISTER REMAINING PROBES]

Interviewer Probes about Question Set A, Part 2

NOTE WHETHER THEY FOLLOWED THE EXPECTED PATH THROUGH THE QUESTIONS BASED ON THEIR SCREENING CRITERIA AND VERBAL RESPONSE.

(SHOW RESPONDENT RELEVANT Qs FROM Q4-9 IN WORD DOCUMENT)

- 5.1. (If Q8 = union, school, group, or association), You indicated you got your coverage through [FILL Q8 RESPONSE]. Can you describe that coverage?
- 5.2. How did you come up with your answer to these questions?
- 5.3. How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions? If needed: How certain are you about your answers?
- 5.4. Are there any words in these question that are confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?
- 5.5. Are there any options that you think are missing from these questions?

13) Section 6: Protocol Conclusion

- 6.1. [IF APPLICABLE:] Before we finish, I want to give my colleagues that are observing a chance to let me know if they have any other questions for you. Give me one moment please. [INTERVIEWER: CHECK FOR DIRECT TEAMS MESSAGE FROM CENSUS BUREAU OBSERVERS ABOUT ANY ADDITIONAL QUESTIONS THEY HAVE FOR THE RESPONDENT. ASK THESE QUESTIONS AND RECORD RESPONSES IN THE CASE SUMMARY.]
- 6.2. Was there anything else you wanted to mention about your health coverage that we haven't talked about today?

Great, thank you very much. Those are all of the questions that I had for you today. Thank you very much for your participation.

- [ENSURE RESPONDENT HAS COMPLETED VOUCHER FORM AND PROVIDE INFORMATION ON RECEIVING \$40 INCENTIVE]
- [TURN OFF THE RECORDER]

Appendix C: ASEC Income Exploratory Interviews Protocol

PARTICIPANT ID #: _____ **DATE:** ____ / ____ / ____

INTERVIEWER'S NAME: _____

START TIME: ____: ____ AM / PM **END TIME:**
____: ____ AM/PM

RECRUITMENT CHARACTERISTICS: ____

R AGE: (YOUNGER THAN 65 / 65+) ____

CHILDREN 5-18 IN HOUSEHOLD? (Y/N) ____

NUMBER OF CHILDREN YOUNGER THAN 13: ____

Introduction

Qualtrics Interviewer Protocol Link:

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_4Iwn9ptU3kl2Xki

[READ OR PARAPHRASE]

Hello, I'm [NAME] with [CONTRACTOR], a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. Thanks for agreeing to help us today. Let me tell you a little about what we will be doing:

We are conducting a study so we can learn how to best ask questions on topics like income in Census Bureau surveys. Since people receive different amounts of income in different ways, it is important to write questions that make sense to everyone and are easy to answer. It is important that everyone understands the questions in the same way because people's answers to the questions help us produce statistics about the U.S. This survey asks questions about you and other people who live with you.

If you agree to take part in this study, I will ask you some questions to learn more about you and your household. Sometimes I will ask you a follow up question that may sound a little strange. For example, I might ask you what a certain word or question means to you or how you came up with your answer. The reason for this is to learn about the process you go through in your mind when you answer the questions. There are no right or wrong answers. We are interviewing people from all over the country to help find the words and questions that will work best for everyone.

Your participation in this interview is very important because it will help the Census Bureau improve its surveys. You will receive \$40 after completing the interview. [CONTRACTOR WILL DESCRIBE HOW RESPONDENT WILL RECEIVE INCENTIVE]

Informed consent

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review and sign this form? [IF NO, PASTE LINK INTO CHAT OR EMAIL IF CHAT NOT AVAILABLE: Can you please open the link to this form shared in the chat?]

[CONSENT LINK]

I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to audio and video record our conversation including a screen recording of you and your computer screen. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 1 hour.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.

[IF OBSERVER IS PRESENT: I also wanted to let you know that this interview is being observed by someone from the Census Bureau/someone else who works on this study. They are observing the interview because they are also interested in learning how our surveys work, and whether we need to change something that does not work.]

Do you have any questions about this information? [IF YES: ADDRESS PARTICIPANT QUESTIONS].

Do you agree to participate in this interview? [IF YES: CONTINUE WITH INTERVIEW. IF NO: ADDRESS ANY PARTICIPANT CONCERNS. IF STILL UNWILLING TO PARTICIPATE, TERMINATE INTERVIEW].

Is it okay if I record this interview today? [IF YES: START RECORDING AND COLLECT VERBAL CONSENT ON RECORDING. IF NO: CONTINUE WITH INTERVIEW WITHOUT RECORDING.]

Now that recording has started, can you confirm that you agree to participate in this interview and be recorded?

[IF PARTICIPANT HAS NOT ALREADY SIGNED FORM]: Please go ahead and sign and date both sections of the form and click "Submit."

INTERVIEWER:

1. DID THE PARTICIPANT HAVE ANY QUESTIONS OR CONCERNS?

- Yes
- No (SKIP TO QUESTION 3)

2. PLEASE SPECIFY:

3. HAS THE PARTICIPANT READ AND SIGNED THE INFORMED CONSENT?

- Yes
- No (END INTERVIEW)

Income type and amount

PROBE RESPONDENT ON THEIR SOURCES OF INCOME. IF NONE, OR IF INTERVIEW IS RUNNING SHORT, ASK PROBES ABOUT OTHER HOUSEHOLD MEMBERS.

General income

1.1. To start, could you please tell me about the ways you make or receive money? If nothing comes to mind, that is okay too.

1.1a. Do you make or receive money from anywhere else? [CAN USE WORD "INCOME" AT THIS POINT IF NEEDED]

1.1b. [IF NOT APPARENT] Do you currently have a job or do other work for pay? (Yes/No)

Q1) Sources of income received:

- 1) Wages or salary
- 2) Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice
- 3) Income from your own farm
- 4) Social Security or Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
- 5) Unemployment compensation
- 6) Interest on savings, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts, and so on
- 7) Dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on
- 8) Pensions and company retirement
- 9) Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on)
- 10) Public assistance or welfare
- 11) Rental properties, estates or trusts

1.2. Now I am going to show you a list of some different ways people make or receive money. I will paste a link in the chat of the Teams meeting. Please let me know when you are able to open it. PASTE LINK IN CHAT.

For the ID, please put in [ID NUMBER] and then click the next button to move to the next screen. You should see Q1. IF RESPONDENT CANNOT OPEN THE LINK, USE THE "FLASHCARD 1" WORD DOCUMENT AS A BACK-UP AND MARK RESPONSES FOR RESPONDENT.

Please go ahead and mark off all sources of income you have and let me know what you selected.,. [HAVE ANSWER (Q1)] INTERVIEWER: MARK ANSWERS IN PROTOCOL.

1.2a. (IF YES TO ANY IN LIST Q1): Can you tell me more about that?

- 1) Wages or salary
- 2) Income from your own nonfarm business, partnership, or professional practice
- 3) Income from your own farm
- 4) Social Security or Supplemental Security Income (SSI)
- 5) Unemployment compensation
- 6) Interest on savings, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts, and so on
- 7) Dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on
- 8) Pensions and company retirement

- 9) Withdrawals from retirement accounts (401K, 403B, IRA, KEOGH, SEP, and so on)
- 10) Public assistance or welfare
- 11) Rental properties, estates or trusts

1.3. Are there any words or phrases on this list that are confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

Self-employment income

2.1. Can you tell me more about your job or any other work you do for pay? PROBE TO GET A SENSE OF INDUSTRY AND OCCUPATION

2.1a. Who pays you for your work? How do you get paid?

2.2. Sometimes people forget about or do not report small amounts of money they earn, or work that they do on the side in addition to a primary job. Did you have any of these kinds of sources of money this year?

2.2a. (IF YES TO 2): Tell me more about that.

2.2b. Is there anything the Census Bureau could do to remind people of these types of income or encourage them to include them in their answers?

Q2) List:

- 1) Babysitting or childcare
- 2) Hair, beauty, or other personal care services
- 3) Direct sales programs like Avon, Scentsy, Herbalife, or doTERRA
- 4) Landscaping
- 5) Delivery services like Instacart, DoorDash, or Ubereats
- 6) Other app-based jobs like Uber or Lyft
- 7) Selling handmade items, in person or online on sites like Etsy
- 8) Re-selling items, in person or online on sites like eBay
- 9) Responding to surveys online for money
- 10) Social media-related income, such as sponsored posts, YouTube video views, or streaming subscriptions
- 11) Other services paid for in cash or via an app like Venmo or Cash App

2.3. [SHOW LIST (Q2)] Going back to the link I sent you earlier, can you press the next button to move forward to Q2? Can you take a look at this list and let me know if you had any of these sources of income? If you did, go ahead and mark them off.

2.3a (IF YES TO ANY IN LIST Q2): Tell me more about that.

2.4. (IF NOT APPARENT): Would you consider yourself to be employed by [ENTITY WHO PAYS THEM FROM PROBE 1/1a/1b]? Would you consider yourself to be self-employed? What about an independent contractor?

Retirement income

3.1. (IF R MENTIONED THIS TYPE OF INCOME IN Q1) Earlier you said that you received retirement income. Tell me more about that. PROBE TO GET A SENSE OF HOW THEY GET THIS INCOME AND IF IT'S BEING WITHDRAWN/DISTRIBUTED: What kind?

3.1a. How do you receive it?

3.1b. How frequently do you receive it?

3.1c. How much do you receive?

3.2. (IF R IS 65+, DID NOT MENTION THIS TYPE OF INCOME, AND IS NOT CURRENTLY WORKING): Have you had a job or done other work for pay in the past?

3.2a. (IF YES TO 2) Did that job offer any kind of benefits or programs to people who retire? Tell me more about that.

3.2b. Do you know the name of the program?

3.3. (IF R IS 65+, DID NOT MENTION THIS TYPE OF INCOME, AND IS CURRENTLY WORKING): Does your job offer any kind of benefits or programs to people who retire? Tell me more about that.

3.3a. Do you know the name of the program?

3.4 (IF R IS 65+, DID NOT MENTION THIS TYPE OF INCOME, AND IS CURRENTLY WORKING/EVER WORKED): Do you expect to receive any kind of future income or benefit from a former job - for example, a benefit after you retire or stop working? Tell me more about that.

3.4a. Do you know the name of the program?

3.4b. Have you had a job that provided options for you to save money for retirement? Tell me more about that.

3.4bi (IF NEEDED): Did you participate? Do you know the name of the program?

3.4c. Have you ever saved money for retirement on your own, separate from any job you may have had? PROBE TO LEARN MORE ABOUT HOW RESPONDENT SAVED AND TYPE OF ACCOUNT (e.g., savings account, 401K, IRA).

3.4d. Can you tell me more about how you are planning to cover future expenses when you are retired or no longer working?

All: I'm going to ask you to answer a few questions on this topic. Please click the next button in the link I sent you to move onto Q3. Please answer Q3-Q8. I will remind you when to stop. [HAVE R ANSWER SERIES (Q3-Q8)]

Q3) During 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive any pension income from a previous employer or union, other than Social Security or VA benefits? Do not include distributions or withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Q4) (IF YES TO Q3): What was the source of the pension income? Select all that apply.

- ☐ Company
- ☐ Union
- ☐ Federal government
- ☐ State government
- ☐ Local government
- ☐ U.S. military
- ☐ U.S. Railroad Retirement pension
- ☐ Some other source, specify: _____

Q5) During 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive any income from an annuity?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Q6) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household have any retirement accounts such as a 401(k), 403(b), IRA, or another account designed specifically for retirement savings?

- Yes
- No

Q7) (IF YES to Q6): What type of retirement account? Select all that apply.

- ☐ 401(k)
- ☐ 403(b)
- ☐ Roth IRA
- ☐ Regular IRA
- ☐ KEOGH plan
- ☐ Simplified Employee Pension (SEP plan)
- ☐ Another type of retirement account, specify: _____

Q8) Did you or anyone in your household withdraw any money or receive a distribution from a [LIST ALL SELECTED IN PRIOR QUESTION] in 2022, including any distributions that may have been required to take?

- Yes
- No

3.5. Thank you for answering those. I have a few follow-ups to learn more about how you came up with your answers to these questions. If you click the next button, you should be able to see all of Q3-Q8 on one screen. (IF YES TO ANY ITEM NOT ALREADY DISCUSSED): You selected yes to [QUESTION(S)]. Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED:

3.5a. What kind of income do you receive?

3.5b. How do you receive it?

3.5c. How frequently do you receive it?

3.5d. How much do you receive?

3.6. (IF NO TO ANY ITEM: TAILOR PROBE TO ITEMS R DID NOT ENDORSE): Have you looked into participating in any of these types of programs or having these kinds of accounts?

3.6a. (IF YES TO 6): Tell me more about that.

3.7. (IF U.S. RAILROAD RETIREMENT PENSION SELECTED IN Q4): You selected "U.S. Railroad Retirement pension" as a source of pension income. Can you tell me more about why you said yes to this option?

3.8. Are there any terms in these questions that are confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

3.9. Can you think of anything that is missing from these questions that people who are retired might receive?

Public assistance

4.1. (IF PARTICIPANT MENTIONED THIS TYPE OF INCOME IN Q1): Earlier you mentioned receiving public assistance or welfare. Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED TO GET A SENSE OF PROGRAMS THEY ARE INCLUDING:

4.1a. What kind of assistance do you receive?

4.1b. How do you receive it?

4.1c. How frequently do you receive it?

4.1d. How much do you receive?

Q9) At any time during 2022, even for one month, did you or anyone in this household receive any CASH assistance from a state or county welfare program?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

4.2. (ALL): Now I'm going to have you answer another question. Please click the next button so you see Q9. How would you answer this question? Go ahead and mark it off.
[HAVE ANSWER (Q9)]

4.2a. (IF YES TO Q9 AND NOT ALREADY DISCUSSED): Tell me more about that.
PROBE AS NEEDED TO GET A SENSE OF PROGRAMS THEY ARE INCLUDING:

4.2ai. What kind of assistance do you receive?

4.2aii. How do you receive it?

4.2aiii. How frequently do you receive it?

4.2aiv. How much do you receive?

4.2b. (IF NEEDED): What kinds of assistance do you think this question is asking about?

4.2c. I'm going to show you a list of programs. What state do you live in? [OPEN FLASHCARD 2 WORD DOCUMENT. USE CTRL+F TO SEARCH FOR RESPONDENT'S STATE AND SHARE SCREEN] Do you receive any of the types of assistance listed here?

Q10) At any time during 2022, even for one month, did you or anyone in this household receive any CASH assistance from a state or county welfare program?

INCLUDE:

- ☐ *Welfare or welfare to work*
- ☐ *Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)/Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC)*
- ☐ *General assistance*
- ☐ *Diversion payments*
- ☐ *Refugee cash*
- ☐ *General assistance from Indian Affairs.*

Do NOT include:

- ☐ *Food stamps or Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) benefits*
 - ☐ *Supplemental Security Income (SSI)*
 - ☐ *Energy assistance*
 - ☐ *Women, Infants and Children (WIC)*
 - ☐ *School meals*
 - ☐ *Childcare*
 - ☐ *Education assistance*
- ☐ Yes
 - ☐ No

4.3. (ALL): Now I'm going to show you another version of this question. Please click the next button to get to Q10. [SHOW Q10] How would you answer this question? Go ahead and mark it off.

4.3a. (IF YES TO Q10 AND NOT ALREADY DISCUSSED): Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED TO GET A SENSE OF PROGRAMS THEY ARE INCLUDING:

4.3ai. What kind of assistance do you receive?

4.3aii. How do you receive it?

4.3aiii. How frequently do you receive it?

4.3aiv. How much do you receive?

4.3b. (IF NO TO Q10): Have you applied for or received any of these types of assistance in the past?

4.3bi. (IF YES TO 3B): Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED:

4.3bi1. What kind of assistance?

4.4. (ALL): Could you please take a moment to look at the bullet points in this question, starting with "Include" [INDICATE TO SECTION AND PAUSE TO LET RESPONDENT READ.]

4.4a. [IF NEEDED]: Did you receive any of the types of assistance mentioned in either of these lists?

4.4b. Are there any examples on these lists that are confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

4.4c. Can you think of any types of assistance that are missing from these lists?

4.5. (ALL): Are you familiar with any assistance programs in your state that we haven't already mentioned?

4.5a. (IF YES TO 5): Have you applied for or received assistance from any of these state programs? PROBE TO DETERMINE WHETHER THEY HAD ALREADY INCLUDED THIS IN THEIR ANSWER.

Interest and dividends

5.1. (IF R MENTIONED THIS TYPE OF INCOME IN Q1): Earlier you mentioned receiving income from [Interests on saving, CDs, bonds, retirement accounts, and so on/Dividends on stocks, mutual funds, and so on]. Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED TO GET A SENSE OF WHAT THEY ARE INCLUDING:

5.1a. What did you receive?

5.1b. How do you receive it?

5.1c. How frequently do you receive it?

5.1d. How much do you receive?

Q11) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household have money in any of the following? Select all that apply.

- ☐ Interest-earning checking account
- ☐ Savings account
- ☐ Money market fund
- ☐ Certificates of deposit (CDs)
- ☐ Savings bonds
- ☐ Shares of stock in corporations or mutual funds
- ☐ Any other savings or investments that pay interest or dividends, specify:

5.2. (ALL): Now I'm going to have you answer another question. Please click the next button to get to Q11. [HAVE ANSWER MODIFIED QUESTION ON ACCOUNT TYPES

(Q11)] How would you answer this question? Go ahead and mark it off. Tell me more about that.

5.2a. (IF YES TO ANY IN Q11): Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED TO GET A SENSE OF WHAT THEY ARE INCLUDING:

5.2ai. What type of account did you have?

5.2aii. Does that account generate any kind of income?

5.2aiii. [IF YES TO aii] How often does the account generate income?

5.2aiv. [IF YES TO aii] How much income does it generate?

5.2b. Are there any categories on this list that are confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

5.2c. Can you think of anything that is missing from this list?

Q12) (IF "SHARES OF STOCK IN CORPORATIONS OR MUTUAL FUNDS" SELECTED IN Q11): **Did you or anyone in this household receive any capital gains from shares of stock, mutual funds, or other assets in 2022?**

- Yes
- No

5.3. (IF "SHARES OF STOCK IN CORPORATIONS OR MUTUAL FUNDS" SELECTED IN Q11): I'm going to show you one additional question. Please click the next button to move to Q12. [HAVE ANSWER MODIFIED QUESTION ON CAPITAL GAINS (Q12)] How would you answer this question? Go ahead and mark it off.

5.3a. In your own words, what is this question asking you?

Unemployment compensation

6.1. (IF R MENTIONED THIS TYPE OF INCOME IN Q1): Earlier you mentioned you received unemployment compensation. Tell me more about that. PROBE TO GET A SENSE OF HOW THEY GET THIS- THROUGH JOB, PROGRAM, ETC.

Q13) **At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in the household receive any State or Federal unemployment compensation?**

- Yes
- No

6.2. (ALL): Now I'm going to have you click the next button forward to get to Q13. [HAVE ANSWER (Q13)] How would you answer this question? Go ahead and mark it off. Tell me more about that.

6.2a. (IF YES TO Q13): PROBE AS NEEDED TO GET A SENSE OF PROGRAMS THEY ARE INCLUDING: What kind of assistance do you receive?

6.2ai. How do you receive it?

6.2aii. Who was it from?

6.2aiii. How frequently do you receive it?

6.2aiv. How much do you receive?

6.2b. (IF NO TO Q13): Have you ever applied for or received any of these types of assistance in the past?

6.2bi. (IF YES TO 6.2B): Tell me more about that. PROBE AS NEEDED:

6.2bi1. When did you receive it?

6.2bi2. What kind of assistance?

6.2bi3. How do you receive it?

6.2bi4. Who was it from?

6.2bi5. How frequently do you receive it?

6.2bi6. How much do you receive?

6.2c. (IF NO TO Q13 OR IF NEEDED): What kinds of assistance do you think this question is asking about?

Other ASEC questions

Now I'm going to ask you some questions about a few different types of programs and types of expenses. Could you please click the next button to move to Q16 and answer the following questions? I'll let you know when to stop. **[HAVE R ANSWER SERIES (Q16-Q32) IN RESPONDENT INSTRUMENT. ONCE RESPONDENT HAS COMPLETED Q14-Q32 IN QUALTRICS INSTRUMENT, OPEN WORD DOCUMENT WITH Q14-Q32 AND SHARE FOR R TO REVIEW DURING FOLLOW-UP PROBES IN THIS SECTION.]**²

Now I have a few follow-up questions to learn more about how you came up with your answers to these questions. Let's go back and look at some of the questions.

School meals

[ONLY ASK IF CHILDREN 5-18 IN THE HOUSEHOLD INDICATED IN SCREENING. ONLY ASK ABOUT ONE CHILD IF MORE THAN ONE]

Child Screen) Are there any children between the ages of 5-18 in your household?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Child Name) What is the name of that child/one of those children? (open-ended)

Q16) During 2022, did any children ages 5 to 18 in this household usually eat a breakfast, lunch, or both provided by the school? *Select all that apply for each child.*

	Breakfast	Lunch	Did not eat meals offered by school
[Child 1 name]			
[Child 2 name]			

Q17) During 2022, did any of these children receive free or reduced-price school meals? *Select all that apply for each child.*

	Breakfast	Lunch	Did not receive free/reduced-price school meals
[Child 1 name]			
[Child 2 name]			

7.1. [SHOW Q16 AND Q17 IN FLASHCARD DOCUMENT] How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions?

7.2. (IF CHILD ATE ANY MEALS): Can you tell me more about the meals that children in this household ate at school?

7.2a. How were these meals paid for?

7.2b. [IF NEEDED]: Did anyone in your household pay anything for these meals?

7.3. (IF CHILD DID NOT FREE/REDUCED PRICE MEALS): Do you know if any other children at the school eat free or reduced-price meals?

² Brackets and color here indicate interviewer is meant to take action.

- 7.4.** (IF MORE THAN ONE CHILD IN THE HOUSEHOLD) Would your answers be the same or different for the other children in your household?
- 7.5.** Let's take a look at Q16. This question asks if the child "usually" ate a breakfast, lunch, or both provided by the school. What does "usually" mean to you in this question?
- 7.5.a.** Would your answer have changed if this question instead asked if they ever ate a breakfast, lunch, or both provided by the school?

WIC

Q18) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive WIC—the Women, Infants, and Children Nutrition Program?

- Yes
- No

Q19) (IF YES FOR Q18): Who received WIC for themselves or on behalf of a child?
[open-ended]

8.1. [SCROLL TO Q18 AND Q19 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions?

8.1a. [If needed]: How certain are you about your answers?

8.2. (IF YES TO Q18): Can you tell me more about the benefits received from WIC in this household?

8.2a. How were these benefits obtained or received?

8.2b. What types of benefits did you include in your answers to these questions?

SNAP

Q20) At any time during 2022, did you or anyone in this household receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program) or the Food Stamp program, or use a SNAP or food stamp benefit card? Do not include WIC benefits.

- Yes
- No

Q21) At any time during 2022, even for one month, did you or anyone in this household receive any food assistance from a state program name? Do not include WIC benefits. Include SNAP (Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program).

- Yes
- No

Q22) (IF YES TO Q21): Who was covered by that food assistance during 2022?
[open-ended]

9.1. [SCROLL TO Q20-22 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions?

9.1a. (IF NEEDED): How certain are you about your answers?

9.2. (IF YES TO Q20): Can you tell me more about the benefits received from SNAP in this household?

9.2a. How were these benefits obtained or received?

9.2b. What types of benefits did you include in your answers to these questions?

9.2c. Do you or anyone in your household have an EBT card as part of these SNAP benefits?

- 9.3.** [IF PARTICIPANT MENTIONS HAVING AN EBT CARD]: Did you include P-EBT in your answers to these questions?
- 9.4.** [IF YES TO Q20/Q21] Did you include benefits from WIC in any of your answers to these questions?
- 9.5.** Are you aware of any nutritional assistance programs in your state that we haven't already mentioned?

Medical expenses

Premiums

Q23) Last year, how much did you pay out-of-pocket for ALL health insurance premiums covering yourself or others in the household? *Include both comprehensive and supplemental plans (such as vision and dental insurance). Do NOT include Medicare deductions from any Social Security or Social Security Disability payments mentioned earlier.*

[Dollar field]

- 10.1.1.** [SCROLL TO Q23 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer this question?

10.1.1a. [IF NEEDED]: How certain are you about your answer?

- 10.1.2.** What does "premium" mean to you in this question?

- 10.1.3.** Was there anything in this question that was confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

Co-pays and medical care

Q24) Last year, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your OWN medical care, such as copays for doctor and dentist visits, diagnostic tests, prescription medicine, glasses and contacts, and medical supplies? *Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone else in this household.*

[Dollar field]

- 10.2.1.** [SCROLL TO Q24 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer this question?

10.2.1a. [IF NEEDED]: How certain are you about your answer?

10.2.1b. [IF NEEDED]: Whose medical expenses were included in your response?

- 10.2.2.** Was there anything in this question that was confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

- 10.2.3.** Can you think of any types of medical expenses you had last year that are missing from the examples in these questions?

- 10.2.4.** What do you see as the difference between these two questions, if any
[POINT TO QUESTIONS 23 AND 24]?

Out-of-pocket costs

Q25) Last year, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your non-prescription healthcare products such as vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, pain relievers,

quit smoking aids, and anything else not yet reported? *Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.*

[Dollar field]

Q26) Last year, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your OWN medical care (e.g., copays for doctor and dentist visits, diagnostic tests, prescription medicine, glasses and contacts, and medical supplies) AND non-prescription healthcare products (e.g., vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, pain relievers, quit smoking aids, and other expenses)? *Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.*

[Dollar field]

10.3.1. [SCROLL TO Q25 AND Q26 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions?

10.3.1a. [IF NEEDED]: How certain are you about your answers?

10.3.1b. [IF NEEDED]: Whose medical expenses were included in your response?

10.3.2. Was there anything in these questions that was confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

10.3.3. Can you think of any types of medical expenses you had last year that are missing from the examples in these questions?

10.3.4. What do you see as the difference between these two questions, if any [POINT TO QUESTIONS 25 AND 26]?

10.3.5. Are there any expenses that you counted in your answer to more than one question? Tell me more about that.

Energy assistance

Q27) In 2022, did you receive energy assistance to help pay heating and cooling costs from the federal, state, or local government? *This assistance can be received directly by the household or it can be paid directly to the electric company, gas company, or fuel dealer.*

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

11.1. [SCROLL TO 27 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer this question?

11.1a. [IF NEEDED]: How certain are you about your answers?

11.2. Was there anything in these questions that was confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

11.3. (IF PARTICIPANT REPORTS RECEIVING ANY ENERGY ASSISTANCE (INCLUDING ANY ADDITIONAL/UNEXPECTED CHECK): Could you tell me more about the energy assistance that you received?

11.3a. How was this energy assistance obtained or received?

11.3b. What types of energy assistance did you include in your answers to these questions?

- 11.4.** (IF PARTICIPANT DID NOT REPORT ANY ENERGY ASSISTANCE): Did you use anything other than your regular income to pay your heating and cooling costs? If nothing comes to mind, that is okay too.

Housing assistance

Q28) Is this public housing, that is, is it owned by a local housing authority or other public agency?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Q29) Are you paying lower rent because the Federal, State, or local government is paying part of the cost?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

- 12.1.** [SCROLL TO Q28 AND Q29 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions?

12.1a. [IF NEEDED]: How certain are you about your answers?

- 12.2.** Was there anything in these questions that was confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

- 12.3.** What does “public housing” mean to you in this question?

12.3a. How about “Section 8”? What does that mean to you?

- 12.4.** (IF PARTICIPANT REPORTS PAYING LOWER RENT BECAUSE THE FEDERAL, STATE, OR LOCAL GOVERNMENT IS PAYING PART OF THE COST): Could you tell me more about the program paying part of your rent? For example, what type of program is it and who offers/sponsors it?

Child care

Q30) Now we want to ask about some of your expenses for children. Did you or anyone in this household PAY for the care of any children while you or they worked, searched for work or were in training/education in 2022?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

[ONLY PROBE ABOUT ONE CHILD IF MORE THAN ONE]

Q31) Do you or does anyone in this household currently use any of the following types of child care for any child? Select all that apply.

- ☐ Pre-kindergarten or 3-K
- ☐ Head Start
- ☐ Preschool, nursery school, or daycare center
- ☐ Family daycare or paid care provided in someone else’s home
- ☐ A paid babysitter or nanny in the home
- ☐ Free care with a relative

- ☐ Paid care with a relative
- ☐ Any other type of child care, specify: _____

Q32) Do you or does anyone in this household receive government assistance, for instance a voucher or child care subsidy, to help pay for any child's child care?

Yes
No

13.1. [SCROLL TO Q30-Q32 IN FLASHCARD] How easy or difficult was it to answer these questions?

13.1a. [IF NEEDED]: How certain are you about your answers?

13.2. Was there anything in these questions that was confusing to you, or that you think other people might not understand?

13.3. [IF MORE THAN ONE CHILD IN THE HOUSEHOLD] Would your answers be the same or different for the other children in your household?

Conclusion

14.1. [IF APPLICABLE:] Before we finish, I want to give my colleagues that are observing a chance to let me know if they have any other questions for you. Give me one moment please. [INTERVIEWER: CHECK FOR TEAMS DIRECT MESSAGE FROM CENSUS BUREAU OBSERVERS ABOUT ANY ADDITIONAL QUESTIONS THEY HAVE FOR THE RESPONDENT. ASK THESE QUESTIONS AND RECORD RESPONSES IN THE CASE SUMMARY.]

14.2. Was there anything else you wanted to mention about your income and program participation that we haven't talked about today?

Great, thank you very much. Those are all of the questions that I had for you today. Thank you very much for your participation.

- [PROVIDE INFORMATION ON RECEIVING \$40 INCENTIVE]
- [TURN OFF THE RECORDER]

Appendix D: Participant Informed Consent Form

What is the purpose of this interview?

The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting interviews to help with the design and content of the Current Population Survey (CPS). The CPS is an important source of information about our nation on topics such as employment, health insurance, and income. It's important that the questions make sense, are easy to answer, and that everyone understands the questions in the same way. You are one of about [ASEC Exploratory Interviews: 50; ASEC Cognitive Interviews: 120] people who are being asked to participate in these interviews. Findings from these interviews will be used to clarify survey questions and instructions on the CPS.

What will happen if I take part in this interview?

If you agree to take part in this study, you will be asked to answer questions about your household, including yourself and other people that live with you. The interview will be conducted virtually by a staff member from RTI International or Research Support Services, who are doing this study for the U.S. Census Bureau.

We would also like to audio and video record the interview. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. It will help us make sure we accurately capture your answers. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview.

How much time is required to participate?

The interview will last approximately [ASEC Exploratory Interviews: 1 hour; ASEC Cognitive Interviews: 90 minutes].

Do I have to take part in this interview?

No, participation in this interview is voluntary. You can stop the interview at any time, and you don't have to answer a question if you don't want to. You will not lose any rights you would normally have if you choose not to join this interview.

What are the possible risks and benefits from participating in this interview?

There are no direct benefits to you from doing this interview. Your involvement in this study will help us improve the questions for the Current Population Survey. There is no more than minimal risk in participating.

How will my privacy be protected?

By law, we are required to keep your answers confidential. The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting this study under the authority of 13 U.S.C. Sections 131, 141, 182, 193, and 196. Your privacy is protected by the Privacy Act of 1974 (5 U.S.C. Section 552a). Only

research staff from the U.S. Census Bureau, RTI International, and Research Support Services will know your answers to interview questions. The Census Bureau can use your responses only to produce statistics and is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you or other members of your household.

This collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB). This eight-digit OMB approval number, 0607-XXXX, confirms this approval and expires on XX/XX/20XX. Without this approval, we could not conduct this study.

How will I be compensated?

You will receive \$40.

What if I have questions about the interview?

If you have concerns or questions about the interview, you may contact RTI's project director, Patty LeBaron, at 312-777-5204 or plebaron@rti.org.

Participant's Agreement:

I have read the information provided above. I voluntarily agree to participate in this interview.

- ☐ I agree for this interview to be audio and video recorded.
- ☐ I do not agree for this interview to be audio and video recorded.

Electronic Signature of Research Participant

Date

Typed Name of Research Participant